

BRANDSTRO

Master Operating Guide

Every Brandstro document in one place, explained step by step, and turned into a blueprint for the ERP.

Combines: Creative Head Leadership Handbook · Performance Incentive Plan · Role briefs for the CRM, HR / Admin, R&D, Sketch Artist, Logo Team Leader, Logo Designer, Packaging Team Leader and Packaging Designer

Part A (this guide): explanation, analysis and ERP blueprint

Part B (appendix): all 10 original PDFs, unchanged, bookmarked

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START HERE

How to Read This Guide

Brandstro's rules currently live in ten separate PDFs written for different readers. This guide puts them into one picture: what the business sells, who does what, how work moves, how people are measured and paid, and what an ERP has to model to run all of it.

Who this is for

Anyone designing or building the Brandstro ERP: the Founder, a product designer, or a developer who has never worked in a branding agency. You don't need to read the originals first. Every rule below points back to the document it came from.

How it is organised

Chapter	What you get	Read it if you want to...
2. At a glance	The whole business on one page	a 5-minute overview
3. Source documents	What each of the 10 PDFs is for	to know which document says what
4. What Brandstro sells	Products, prices, monthly targets, capacity	to design products, orders, billing
5. Organisation	People, reporting lines, salary bands	to design users, roles, permissions
6. Project lifecycle	Every stage from lead to final files	to design the project workflow and statuses
7. Roles in detail	Each role's duties, rhythm, checklists, KPIs	to design each person's screens and tasks
8. Company-wide rules	SLAs, scope, escalation, naming, QC, leave	to design validations and automations
9. Incentive plan	Targets and bonus formulas, recalculated	to design the incentive/payroll engine
10. Leadership system	The Creative Head's management framework	to design dashboards, reviews, scorecards
11. Tools today → ERP	Sheets and WhatsApp groups the ERP replaces	to plan data migration
12. ERP blueprint	Modules, entities, statuses, permissions, alerts	to start building
13. Gaps and contradictions	Where documents disagree or are silent	to know what to ask the Founder first
14. Glossary and numbers	Terms and key numbers	a quick reference

Conventions used

- **Source tags** such as [CRM] or [Handbook §24] show which document a rule comes from.
- Amounts are in Indian Rupees (₹), written in Indian digit grouping as in the originals (₹3,53,500 = 353,500).
- **ERP note** boxes turn a business rule into something the system must do.
- **Watch out** boxes (red) mark a contradiction or gap between documents. These are collected in Chapter 13.

Source tags used in this guide

[Handbook] Creative Head Leadership Handbook · [Incentive] Performance Incentive Plan · [CRM] [HR] [R&D] [Sketch] [LogoTL] [LogoDes] [PackTL] [PackDes] = the individual role briefs.

CHAPTER 2

Brandstro at a Glance

A young branding agency in Tamil Nadu that designs logos, brand identities, labels and packaging for clients, run by its Founder (Zameel) with a 12-person production and support team plus a Creative Head.

The business in one paragraph

Brandstro sells four products: **Logo Design** (₹6,000), a **Branding + Logo Package** (₹15,000), **Standalone Label Design** (₹2,500) and **Standalone Packaging Design** (₹3,500). The client pays 50% up front and 50% before final files are released. Every project starts with **research** (R&D). Logo work then goes to a **hand sketch** (Sketch Artist) and on to **digital design** (Logo Team). Packaging, labels and branding collateral go to the **Packaging Team**. A **Team Leader review** checks all work before the **Client Relationship Manager (CRM)**, the only person who talks to clients, presents it. Corrections loop back until the client signs off. Then the second payment is collected and final files are delivered.

The key numbers

Measure	Value	Source
Company age (when handbook was written)	About 3 months	[Handbook \$16]
Monthly sales target	47 client engagements = ₹3,53,500 revenue	[Incentive]
Team covered by incentive plan	12 people	[Incentive]
Fixed monthly payroll	₹1,26,000	[Incentive]
Bonus payout if everyone hits target	₹61,900	[Incentive]
Overheads (rent, software, electricity, misc.)	₹17,000 / month	[Incentive]
Profit at full target	₹1,48,600 (~42% margin; required band 40–50%)	[Incentive]
The hard capacity limit	Sketch Artist: 1 concept set/day ≈ 24/month	[Sketch][Incentive]
The problem that triggered all this	30 new clients in a month, only 6–8 projects completed	[Handbook \$17]

The six ideas that run through every document

Principle	What it means in practice	Why it matters for the ERP
1. One voice to the client	Only the CRM (or Founder) speaks to clients. Designers, R&D and the Sketch Artist never do unless authorised.	Client messages and submissions must flow through the CRM. Other roles need no client-contact screens.
2. If it's not in the sheet, it didn't happen	WhatsApp is for speed, but every status change, deadline, feedback item and approval must be logged.	The ERP becomes the single source of truth. WhatsApp only notifies.
3. Nothing skips Team Leader review	Every logo, label, pack and collateral piece passes a QC checklist before a client sees it.	A mandatory 'TL Review' status gate with a checklist record.
4. Scope is protected	A correction refines what was agreed. A new direction or extra deliverable is a scope change, escalated to the Founder.	Feedback must be classified; scope changes need an approval workflow.
5. Bottlenecks are protected	R&D and the Sketch Artist cap the whole company's output. Their queues follow strict priority.	Queue management with P1/P2/P3 priority and capacity visibility.
6. Fix systems, not symptoms	Recurring problems get a checklist, tracker or rule, not a pep talk.	Dashboards, trend reports and repeat-issue detection are core features, not extras.

CHAPTER 3

The Source Documents

Ten PDFs, 107 pages. One long leadership handbook, one financial plan, and eight short role briefs that share the same layout.

#	Document	Pages	Written for	What it covers
1	Creative Head Leadership Handbook (v1.0)	70	Creative Head + Founder	49 sections in 8 parts: the Creative Head's role, leading Team Leaders, running the department, agency-specific leadership, operating rhythm, a 30/60/90-day plan, 16 office scenarios, a monthly scorecard.
2	Performance Incentive Plan (final draft)	13	Founder	Monthly sales target, each role's baseline, target and bonus per project, company economics (revenue, payroll, bonus, profit).
3	CRM Brief	3	Client Relationship Manager	Client onboarding, SLAs, correction flow, scope rules, complaints, escalation.
4	HR / Admin Brief	3	HR / Admin	Attendance, leave, records, discipline, onboarding and exit.
5	R&D Brief	3	R&D researcher	Research brief template, P1/P2/P3 queue, handoff rules, 2 briefs/day benchmark.
6	Sketch Artist Brief	3	Sketch Artist	3–5 distinct concepts per logo, quality checklist, 1 set/day benchmark.
7	Logo Team Leader Brief	3	Logo Team Leader	Assigning work, Logo QC checklist, mandatory review, file naming, escalation.
8	Logo Designer Brief	3	Logo Designers	Daily workflow, self-QC, file naming, corrections, KPIs.
9	Packaging Team Leader Brief	3	Packaging Team Leader	Assigning work, print-readiness QC, branding-package planning.
10	Packaging Designer Brief	3	Packaging Designers	Packaging, labels and collateral workflow, print-ready checklist, file naming.

How the documents fit together

The **eight role briefs** all share one structure: a mission quote, *What you own*, *Your rhythm* (daily/weekly/monthly), a workflow, a checklist, *What you decide vs. what you escalate*, KPIs, and a *Day 1* list. Each says it is part of the **'Brandstro Internal Operating System — Phase 1'** and points to a **master SOP** (e.g. 'Full SOP: Section 6.3'). The **Incentive Plan** puts numbers on the same roles. The **Handbook** sits above them all: it describes how the Creative Head should manage the Team Leaders who run those roles.

Watch out: the master SOP is referenced but not included

Every brief says 'Full detail in the master SOP, Sections 6.x, 7, 9, 10, 12–20, 22, 24, 28–31, 34–38'. That SOP is not among the ten files. It probably holds details the ERP needs (package definitions, revision limits, folder structure 01–08, payment terms). Ask the Founder for it before finalising the data model.

CHAPTER 4

What Brandstro Sells

Four products. The product mix is chosen around one fact: the Sketch Artist can produce only about 24 sketches a month.

Products, prices and monthly targets

Product	Price	Monthly target	Revenue	Who produces it
Logo Design Only	₹6,000	8	₹48,000	R&D → Sketch Artist → Logo Team
Branding + Logo Package	₹15,000	16	₹2,40,000	R&D → Sketch → Logo Team (logo) + Packaging Team (collateral)
Standalone Label Design	₹2,500 (1st)	15	₹37,500	R&D → Packaging Team
Standalone Packaging Design	₹3,500 (1st)	8	₹28,000	R&D → Packaging Team
Total		47	₹3,53,500	

What is inside the Branding + Logo Package

From [PackDes], [PackTL] and [Incentive]: the logo, plus a coordinated set of non-logo deliverables: **brand guideline book, visiting card, letterhead, t-shirt, and custom packaging**. The Packaging Team Leader must plan this whole set 'as one coordinated job, not scattered pickups'. A logo client presentation is typically a **~5-page mockup** [Handbook §24].

Why the mix looks like this (the capacity logic)

- Logo-only and Branding both need a sketch. $8 + 16 = 24$ **sketches**, exactly the Sketch Artist's monthly capacity.
- The Sketch Artist can't do more, so the plan sells more of the **higher-value** Branding package (₹15,000) and fewer Logo-only jobs (₹6,000) within the same 24 slots. Revenue rises with no extra sketch work.
- Label and Packaging were cut (Label $28 \rightarrow 15$, Packaging $12 \rightarrow 8$). This gives the Packaging Team slack: it uses about **58 of its 84** available working days a month ($4 \text{ people} \times 21 \text{ days}$).
- Result: fewer projects (47, down from 64) and more revenue (₹3,53,500, up from ₹3,46,000).

Risk the plan itself names

Branding packages carry more deliverables per project than Logo-only. With 16 a month (up from 10), watch whether the Logo and Packaging teams keep pace. The ERP's capacity dashboard should track this from month one.

Payment terms

- **50% advance** when the order is confirmed. Work (the discovery call and R&D) starts only after this [Handbook §24][R&D: queue is 'in the order payment was confirmed'].
- **50% final** collected **before** final files are handed over [Handbook §24].
- The CRM confirms payment status per project, and on-time 50/50 collection is part of the CRM's bonus [Incentive].

ERP note

Products need: name, base price, *price for additional units* (the '(1st)' in label/packaging pricing suggests a different price for extra labels/packs), included deliverables, included revision rounds, and which teams/stages they route through.

Orders need two invoice milestones (advance and final), and 'final files released' must be blocked until the final payment is recorded.

CHAPTER 5

Organisation & People

A small, flat agency: a Founder who also sells, a Creative Head over the creative teams, two Team Leaders, two single-person bottleneck roles, and two support roles.

Reporting structure

Founder (Zameel) sales · pricing · hiring · escalations			
Reports to Founder	Reports to Creative Head	Reports to Logo TL	Reports to Packaging TL
Creative Head Client Relationship Manager (CRM) HR / Admin	R&D (1) Sketch Artist (1) Logo Team Leader (1) Packaging Team Leader (1) Internal Content Team Leader	Logo Designers (3 per Incentive; 4 per LogoTL brief)	Packaging Designers (3)

Headcount, pay and targets

Role	People	Base salary	Target monthly earning	Reports to	Brief
R&D	1	₹10,000	₹12,000	Creative Head	[R&D]
Sketch Artist	1	₹10,000	₹15,000	Creative Head	[Sketch]
Logo Designer	3	₹10,000	₹15,000	Logo TL	[LogoDes]
Logo Team Leader	1	₹12,000	₹17,000	Creative Head	[LogoTL]
Packaging Designer	3	₹10,000–12,000 (one senior at ₹12,000)	₹15,000–17,000	Packaging TL	[PackDes]
Packaging Team Leader	1	₹12,000	₹17,000	Creative Head	[PackTL]
Client Relationship Manager	1	₹10,000	₹20,000	Founder	[CRM]
HR / Admin (called 'HR / Personal Assistant' in Incentive)	1	₹10,000	₹15,000	Founder	[HR]
Total covered by incentive plan	12	₹1,26,000			
Creative Head	1	not stated	not stated	Founder	[Handbook]
Internal Content Team	not stated	not stated	not stated	Creative Head	[Handbook §29]

Check of the payroll figure: 10k (R&D) + 10k (Sketch) + 30k (3 Logo) + 12k (Logo TL) + 32k (Packaging: 12k + 10k + 10k) + 12k (Pack TL) + 10k (CRM) + 10k (HR) = **₹1,26,000**. This matches the Incentive Plan and confirms it assumes 3 Logo Designers and **excludes the Creative Head and the Content Team**.

Who decides what: the authority layers

Layer	Owns	Source
Founder	Business direction, pricing and packages, sales, major escalations, culture, final call on hiring, discipline warnings, HR policy, refunds.	[Handbook \$05][CRM][HR]
Creative Head	Department-wide performance, Team Leader development, cross-team coordination, productivity, quality standards, capacity planning, process improvement. Approves urgent (P1) R&D projects, missed client deadlines, extra unpaid revisions.	[Handbook \$05][LogoTL][R&D]
Team Leaders	Daily team management, task allocation, first-level QC review, team deadlines, coaching, rework decisions.	[Handbook \$05][LogoTL][PackTL]
Team Members	Executing assigned work to standard and deadline, flagging blockers early, following process.	[Handbook \$05]
CRM (side role)	All client communication, in-scope corrections, complaint first response, payment follow-up.	[CRM]
HR / Admin (side role)	Attendance, leave, records. Administers policy but does not set it. Never involved in creative decisions.	[HR]

Watch out: Logo Team size

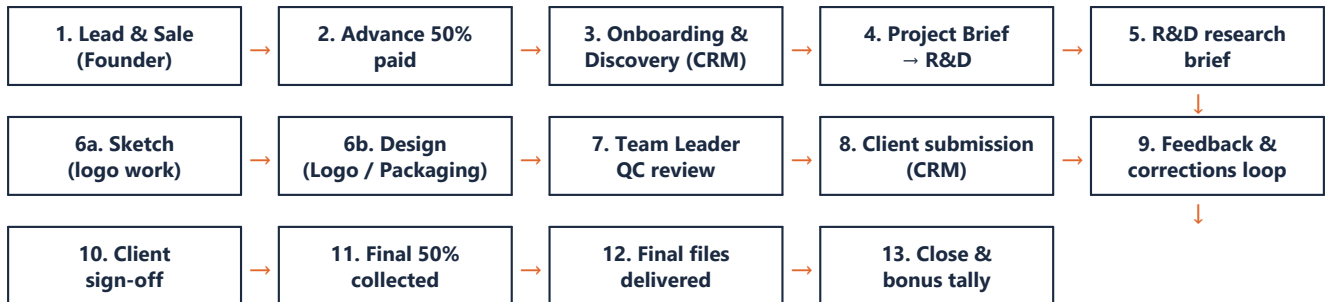
The Logo Team Leader brief says 'balance load across all **4** designers ... you're not just the 5th designer'. The Incentive Plan and payroll use **3** Logo Designers. The Handbook says a 'four-person Logo team' (likely TL + 3). The ERP should not hard-code team sizes, but the Founder must confirm the real number because it changes capacity and bonus targets.

CHAPTER 6

How a Project Flows, End to End

The most important chapter for the ERP. It combines the flows in the CRM, R&D, Sketch, Logo and Packaging briefs and the 8-stage process in Handbook §24 into one lifecycle.

The master lifecycle



Stage by stage

#	Stage	Owner	What happens	Output / record	Source
1	Lead & sale	Founder (Sales)	Leads arrive in the 'Leads' WhatsApp group. The Founder sells a package and price and writes handover notes (package, price, promises made).	Sales handover notes	[CRM][Incentive]
2	Advance payment	CRM / Founder	50% advance confirmed. This date sets the project's position in the R&D queue (FIFO).	Payment record	[Handbook \$24][R&D]
3	Onboarding & discovery	CRM	Add to Client Database. Send welcome message (package, price, next step). Schedule the meeting in the 'Client Meetings' group. Run a structured discovery call. Collect logos, photos and references into the Drive project folder.	Client record, discovery notes, materials	[CRM]
4	Project Brief handed to R&D	CRM	Clarify requirements before they reach R&D. Hand over the completed Project Brief with its priority. Missing info is flagged [CLIENT INPUT REQUIRED], not assumed.	Project Brief	[CRM][Handbook \$27]
5	R&D research	R&D	Work the queue by priority (P1 > P2 FIFO > P3). Produce the structured research brief (6 sections). Save it to 02_R&D. Mark it complete in the Project Tracker. Tag the next owner and confirm pickup.	Research brief	[R&D]
6a	Sketch (logo & branding only)	Sketch Artist	3–5 genuinely distinct concepts (e.g. wordmark vs symbol vs combination mark), with a one-line rationale each. Self-check, then submit to the Logo TL with the research brief attached.	Concept set	[Sketch]
6b	Design development	Logo Designer / Packaging Designer	TL assigns by load. Logo: typography, colour, composition, refinement, mockup. Packaging: layout, typography, colour, info hierarchy, mockup, print-ready artwork (bleed, safe area, CMYK). Designer self-checks the QC list.	Versioned design files	[LogoDes][PackDes]
7	Team Leader review	Logo TL / Packaging TL	Mandatory QC checklist on every piece. Pass, or send back for rework. Nothing reaches the Creative Head or CRM without TL sign-off.	QC checklist log	[LogoTL][PackTL]
8	Client submission	CRM	CRM sends the presentation/mockup. Acknowledge the submission the same business day it's received from production.	Submission record	[CRM]
9	Feedback & corrections	CRM → TL → Designer	CRM documents the feedback and checks it's clear. In scope: assign to the team. Scope change: escalate to the Founder. Designer fixes, TL reviews again, CRM resubmits.	Feedback log, revision count	[CRM]
10	Client sign-off	CRM	Explicit final approval. The Handbook notes this step did not exist formally before; the CRM brief now requires it.	Approval record	[CRM][Handbook \$24]
11	Final payment	CRM	Collect the remaining 50%. Follow up once, then escalate to the Founder if it's still unpaid.	Payment record	[CRM][Handbook \$24]
12	Final files	Designer / TL	Only TL-approved final versions go into 08_Final Files and are handed over.	Final file set	[LogoDes][PackDes]
13	Close	TL + CRM	TL logs completion with the revision count against the person. CRM confirms payment. These feed the month-end bonus tally.	Completion record	[Incentive]

The three routes through production

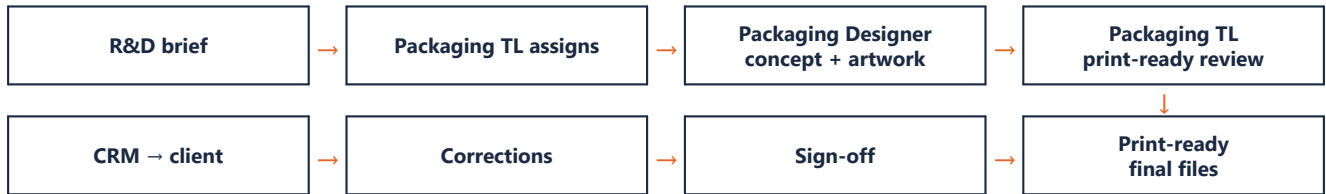
Route A: Logo Design Only



Route B: Branding + Logo Package

The logo follows Route A. In parallel, or after the logo is approved (the documents don't say which; see Chapter 13), the Packaging TL plans the whole collateral set (guidelines, visiting card, letterhead, t-shirt, packaging) as one job for the Packaging Team.

Route C: Standalone Label or Packaging



Watch out: the sketch step is not always used

Handbook §18 and §24 say that today R&D sometimes briefs the Sketch Artist, sometimes sends ideas straight to Logo, and sometimes a logo designer originates the concept. The sketch step is 'sometimes skipped'. The briefs describe the ideal path.

ERP implication: route is a **per-project choice** recorded on the project, so everyone can see which path applies.

Throughput benchmarks (capacity data)

Function	Headcount	Benchmark	≈ Monthly capacity	Source
R&D	1	2 project briefs/day	~42–48	[R&D][Handbook §17]
Sketch Artist	1	1 concept set/day	24 (stated)	[Sketch][Incentive]
Logo Designer	3 (or 4)	1 logo/day each	Target 7 finished logos/month each (revision cycles included)	[LogoDes][Incentive]
Packaging Designer	3	1 design/day each	84 team days available, ~58 planned	[PackDes][Incentive]
Standalone label/pack	—	1–2 days + a few days for confirmation rounds	—	[Handbook §17]

CHAPTER 7

Roles in Detail

Everything each role brief says, in the same order for every role. Founder and Creative Head duties come from the Handbook and the 'escalate to' columns of the other briefs.

Founder (Zameel)

- Sells: owns the monthly sales target of 47 engagements / ₹3,53,500 [Incentive]. The CRM receives 'Sales handover notes' from them.
- Decides: pricing, packages, discounts, new deliverables, deadline changes promised to clients, scope changes, refunds and contract disputes [CRM].
- Receives escalations: client threatens to cancel or demands a refund; payment unresolved after one follow-up; team wellbeing or reputation risk [CRM].
- People: approves discipline warnings, owns HR policy, final call on hiring [HR][Handbook §05].
- Reviews the Creative Head's 13-category monthly scorecard [Handbook §45].

Creative Head

"I own the health and performance of the overall creative department — the strength of its Team Leaders, the productivity, quality and accountability of every team, and the systems that let it grow without breaking." [Handbook §03]

- Sits above the Logo TL, Packaging TL, R&D, the Sketch Artist and the Internal Content Team. Promoted from Logo Team Leader after turning that team around.
- Is **not** a bigger Team Leader, not a designer, and not a client manager. The job is making Team Leaders better.
- Receives escalations (L3 in the TL briefs): client-facing deadline at risk, the same designer's quality issue recurring 2+ times, whole team overloaded, R&D queue overload, unclear R&D direction reported by the Sketch Artist.
- Approves: P1 urgent R&D projects, missed client deadlines, extra unpaid revisions (together with the Founder).
- Runs: the daily leadership check-in, the weekly Team Leader review (8 questions), the monthly department review. Full system in Chapter 10.

Client Relationship Manager (CRM)

"You are the single bridge between the client and the production team ... You catch unclear requirements before they cost the team a redo, and you catch scope creep before anyone agrees to it." [CRM]

Owns / does

- Client onboarding and welcome communication
- Client meetings: requirement collection and briefing; collecting references, brand materials and files
- Clarifying requirements before they reach R&D
- Sending updates and submissions to clients; following up for approvals and final sign-off
- Collecting feedback and forwarding it internally in a structured way; coordinating corrections
- Maintaining the Client Database; first-level complaint handling
- Per Incentive: collects payments (50/50) and 'closes deals'; pushes both TLs to keep projects moving

Rhythm

When	What
Daily	Check the Client Meetings WhatsApp group. Respond to open threads within SLA. Update the Project Tracker on any status change. Log new feedback.
Weekly	Review every active client for pending approvals or stalled threads. Flag anything unresolved for 3+ days to the Creative Head.
Monthly	Summarise client satisfaction signals (delays, complaints, praise) for the monthly review.

Onboarding checklist (7 steps)

- Review Sales handover notes (package sold, price, promises made)
- Add client to the Client Database
- Send welcome message confirming package, price and next step
- Schedule the client meeting; post it to the Client Meetings group
- Run a structured discovery call (brand story, references, must-haves / must-avoids)
- Collect materials (logos, photos, references) into the Drive project folder
- Hand the completed Project Brief to R&D with a priority

Decides vs. escalates

Situation	Who decides
Accept a clearly in-scope correction	CRM decides
Tone and cadence of client communication	CRM decides
Promise a new deliverable, discount or deadline change	Escalate to Founder/Sales
Anything that looks like a scope change	Escalate before agreeing
Authorise a designer to speak to a client	CRM's call, but log the exception

Measured on

KPI	Measured via	Reviewed
Client response-time SLA adherence	Project Tracker timestamps	Weekly
Approval turnaround time	Project Tracker timestamps	Weekly
(Bonus) projects cleanly closed + paid on time	TL completion logs + payment records	Monthly

Day 1 checklist

- Get access to the Client Database, Project Tracker and both WhatsApp groups (Leads, Client Meetings)
- Log every active client's real status today; pick up mid-handover clients from Sales first
- Send a status update to any client silent for 3+ days

R&D (Research & Creative Direction)

"Every logo and packaging project in Brandstro starts with you ... your output is the most important single input in the entire production line." [R&D]

Owns / does

- Industry, competitor and category research
- Target audience and brand positioning research
- Visual, symbol and cultural reference research
- A structured research brief, not raw inspiration links
- Handing direction to the Sketch Artist (logo) or the Packaging Team (packaging)

- Working ahead on queued projects when capacity allows

Rhythm

When	What
Daily	Work the queue in priority order. One structured brief per project. Log the handoff in the Project Tracker the moment it's done.
Weekly	Report queue length and flag at-risk projects to the Creative Head before they become missed deadlines.

Research brief template (every project, every time)

- Client and business overview
- Target audience
- Competitor / category references (3–5 examples)
- Positioning direction (1–2 sentence recommendation)
- Visual / symbol direction (mood, motifs, cultural references)
- Anything the client explicitly wants included or avoided

Queue priority

Priority	Rule
P1 Urgent	Founder/Creative Head approved. Jumps the queue. Only one P1 active at a time.
P2 Standard	Normal paid project, worked in the order payment was confirmed (FIFO).
P3 Ahead	Upcoming project worked while waiting on a dependency. Only when no P1/P2 is ready.

Handoff rule

- Mark the brief complete in the Project Tracker
- Tag the next owner (Sketch Artist for logo, Packaging Team for packaging)
- Save the brief in the project's Drive folder 02_R&D
- **An unacknowledged handoff counts as not yet started.** Confirm the next owner has picked it up.

Decides vs. escalates

Situation	Who decides
Re-order same-priority projects for efficiency	R&D decides
Depth and direction of research	R&D decides
Deprioritise a Founder/CRM-flagged urgent project	Needs Creative Head approval
Queue consistently overloaded	Flag to Creative Head (don't silently work longer)
Brief from CRM is unclear	Flag back to CRM before researching on an assumption
A P1 lands	Drop everything; others queue behind it

Measured on

KPI	Measured via	Reviewed
Briefs delivered on time	Project Tracker	Weekly
Briefs requiring rework	Team Leader feedback	Weekly
(Bonus) concepts beyond baseline, by downstream revision tier	Project Tracker	Monthly

Day 1 checklist

- Access to the Project Tracker and Drive folders

- Pull today's queue in payment-confirmed order; spot anything at risk
- Use the research brief template from the very next project
- Tell the Creative Head your realistic daily capacity

Sketch Artist

"You're the bridge between R&D's research and the Logo Team's digital production ... you don't need to make it pretty yet, you need to make it right." [Sketch]

Owns / does

- Study the research brief and creative direction
- Produce 3–5 **distinct** sketch concepts per logo project (e.g. wordmark vs symbol vs combination mark, not variations of one idea)
- Explain the rationale for each (one line)
- Submit to the Logo Team Leader with the research brief attached
- Refine only when the Logo Team or Creative Head asks for a specific direction adjustment
- Handoff to the Logo Team completes the Sketch Artist's part. Don't polish sketches into finished art.

Rhythm

When	What
Daily	Work the sketch queue in priority order; hand off completed sets the same day where possible.
Weekly	Report queue length to the Creative Head. Flag any unclear R&D direction before guessing.

Quality self-check

- Concepts are visually distinct from each other
- Concepts trace back to the brief's positioning and visual direction
- Concepts can scale to a clean digital logo (not overly intricate)

Decides vs. escalates

Situation	Who decides
Which directions to explore within the brief	Sketch Artist decides
Order of same-priority sketches	Sketch Artist decides
R&D brief unclear or contradictory	Flag to R&D / Creative Head
Queue consistently overloaded	Flag to Creative Head early

Measured on

KPI	Measured via	Reviewed
Concepts delivered on time	Project Tracker	Weekly
Concept sets requiring redirection	Project Tracker	Weekly
(Bonus) % of sketches the Logo Team completes with no rework	Logo TL records	Monthly

Day 1 checklist

- Access to the Project Tracker and Drive folders
- Pull today's queue; confirm each brief is complete before starting
- Apply the 3–5 distinct-directions standard
- Tell the Creative Head your realistic daily capacity

Logo Team Leader

"You lead the Logo Team's output and quality ... You manage the system and the people; you're not just the 5th designer." [LogoTL]

Owns / does

- Assigning incoming sketch sets and briefs across the designers, **by current load in the Team Task Tracker**
- Monitoring workload and deadlines; supporting designers who are stuck or behind
- First-level internal review of **every logo, every time** (non-negotiable, even under deadline pressure)
- Coordinating capacity and escalations with the Creative Head; reporting team status daily and weekly
- Enforcing file naming and versioning; own design output (baseline 2 logos/month per Incentive)

Rhythm

When	What
Daily	Assign new sketches/briefs. Review designs completed today against the Logo QC checklist. Flag blockers immediately.
Weekly	Report team output and recurring quality issues to the Creative Head.

Decides vs. escalates

Situation	Who decides
Reassign work within the team	TL decides
Reject a design at review, send for rework	TL decides
Approve a missed client deadline	Escalate to Creative Head
Approve extra unpaid revisions beyond the package	Escalate to Creative Head / Founder
Talk to the client directly	Needs CRM / Founder authorisation
Missed internal deadline	TL re-sequences; escalate if the client deadline is at risk
Quality issue at review	Send back; escalate if it recurs on the same designer 2+ times
Designer overloaded	Rebalance; escalate if the whole team is overloaded
Correction looks like a new direction	Flag to Creative Head (don't quietly redo)

Measured on

KPI	Measured via	Reviewed
Team on-time delivery rate	Project Tracker	Weekly
First-review pass rate	QC checklist logs	Weekly
Client revision rounds per project	Project Tracker	Weekly
Designer throughput (≈1 logo/day/designer)	Team Task Tracker	Weekly

Day 1 checklist

- Access to the Project Tracker, Team Task Tracker and Logo QC checklist
- Check load across designers; rebalance backlog today
- Confirm every in-progress logo has a version number and correct Drive folder
- Brief the team: nothing goes out without TL sign-off

Logo Designer

"You turn a sketch concept and research direction into a professional, presentation-ready logo. Your craft is the product Brandstro sells." [LogoDes]

Owns / does

- Digital development of the assigned concept: typography, colour, composition, refinement
- Self-check against the Logo QC checklist before submitting
- Prepare the client-ready presentation mockup
- Apply correction rounds as assigned by the TL; finalise and hand off approved files
- Follow file naming and folder conventions exactly

Rhythm

When	What
Daily (7 steps)	1 Receive concept + brief from TL → 2 Digital development → 3 Self-QC → 4 Submit to TL → 5 Apply TL feedback → 6 Prepare client mockup → 7 Apply client corrections as assigned; finalise once approved.

Decides vs. escalates

Situation	Who decides
Typography, colour, composition within the brief	Designer decides
How to execute an assigned correction	Designer decides
Is client feedback in scope or a new direction?	Flag to TL (don't guess)
Talking to the client	Not unless CRM/Founder authorises
About to miss a deadline	Tell the TL early, not at the deadline

Measured on

KPI	Measured via	Reviewed
On-time rate	Project Tracker	Weekly
Revision rounds per project	Project Tracker	Weekly
First-review pass rate	QC checklist logs	Weekly
Throughput (≈1 logo/day)	Team Task Tracker	Weekly

Day 1 checklist

- Access to the Drive structure and Team Task Tracker
- Confirm current assignments and deadlines with the TL
- Use the file naming convention from the next save
- Keep the Logo QC checklist at hand

Packaging Team Leader

"Your team covers packaging, labels, and every collateral piece in the Branding Package (visiting card, letterhead, t-shirt, brand guideline book)." [PackTL]

Owns / does

- Assigning packaging, label and collateral work across 3 designers by load
- Planning a full Branding Package's non-logo set as **one coordinated job**
- First-level review against the Packaging QC / print-readiness checklist, every deliverable, every time
- Coordinating capacity and escalations with the Creative Head; daily and weekly status reporting

- Own design output (small baseline per Incentive)

Rhythm

When	What
Daily	Assign work arriving from R&D or a branding-package brief. Review today's completed work against the QC checklist. Flag blockers.
Weekly	Report team output and recurring quality issues to the Creative Head.

Decides vs. escalates

Situation	Who decides
Reassign within team / reject at review	TL decides
Approve a missed client deadline	Escalate to Creative Head
Extra unpaid revisions	Escalate to Creative Head / Founder
Talk to client	Needs CRM / Founder authorisation
Quality/print issue recurs on same designer 2+ times	Escalate to Creative Head
Correction is a new layout direction	Flag to Creative Head

Measured on

KPI	Measured via	Reviewed
Team on-time delivery rate	Project Tracker	Weekly
First-review pass rate	QC checklist logs	Weekly
Client revision rounds per project	Project Tracker	Weekly
Print-readiness pass rate	QC checklist logs	Weekly
Designer throughput (≈1 design/day)	Team Task Tracker	Weekly

Day 1 checklist

- Access to the trackers and Packaging QC checklist
- Rebalance backlog across the 3 designers
- Confirm versioning and Drive locations of in-progress pieces
- Brief the team on the review chain

Packaging Designer

"Precision matters here more than anywhere else in Brandstro — a print mistake is expensive and hard to undo once approved." [PackDes]

Owns / does

- Study the product, brand direction and R&D output
- Develop concepts: layout, typography, colour, information hierarchy
- Mockups and print-ready artwork (correct dimensions, bleed, safe area, CMYK, resolution)
- Covers packaging, labels, visiting cards, letterheads, t-shirts and brand guideline books
- Apply corrections (with a **fresh print-readiness check** if dimensions, bleed or artwork changed); finalise files

Rhythm

When	What
Daily (7 steps)	1 Receive brief → 2 Concept → 3 Mockup + print artwork → 4 Self-check → 5 Submit to TL → 6 Apply TL feedback → 7 Client corrections; finalise print-ready files.

Decides vs. escalates

Situation	Who decides
Layout, typography, colour within the brief	Designer decides
Client feedback in scope?	Flag to TL
Talking to the client	Not unless authorised
About to miss a deadline	Tell the TL early

Measured on

KPI	Measured via	Reviewed
On-time rate	Project Tracker	Weekly
Revision rounds per project	Project Tracker	Weekly
Print-readiness pass rate	QC checklist logs	Weekly
Throughput (≈1 design/day)	Team Task Tracker	Weekly

Day 1 checklist

- Access to Drive and the Team Task Tracker
- Confirm assignments and deadlines
- Use the file naming convention
- Keep the print-readiness checklist at hand

HR / Admin

"You own people administration — attendance, leave, records, and the smooth running of onboarding and exits ... You do not interfere with design or creative decisions." [HR]

Owns / does

- Attendance tracking, corrections and leave management
- Employee records and documentation
- Basic discipline tracking and escalation to the Founder
- Internal administration and company sheet maintenance
- Supporting onboarding and exit processes
- Per Incentive (broader): keeps accounts and pushes the CRM and TLs to keep work moving on the Founder's behalf

Rhythm

When	What
Daily	Log attendance. Flag unapproved absences the same day.
Weekly	Reconcile leave balances. Report discipline issues to the Founder.
Monthly	Attendance trend summary for the monthly review. Keep employee documents current.

Leave process



Onboarding and exit

New employee	Departing employee
Company introduction and business-model walkthrough on Day 1 Confirm reporting manager; set up Drive, Sheets, WhatsApp access Track first-week and first-month review dates	Confirm all active work has a new owner Coordinate access and password recovery Final documentation and clearance

Decides vs. escalates

Situation	Who decides
Log attendance and leave per policy	HR decides
Flag a coverage gap to a TL	Inform, don't resolve
Issue a formal warning	Founder awareness required first
Change HR policy	Founder only
A design/creative question	Redirect to Creative Head
Late arrival, first time	Log; escalate if the pattern repeats
Unapproved absence	Flag same day; inform Founder if it recurs
Employee conflict	Route to TL first; Founder if unresolved or it involves a TL

Measured on

KPI	Measured via	Reviewed
Attendance accuracy	Attendance sheet	Monthly
Onboarding/exit checklist completion	Checklist records	Monthly
(Bonus) team members hitting their own target	Incentive tally	Monthly

Day 1 checklist

- Set up the Attendance/HR sheet and start logging today
- Communicate the working-week pattern to everyone
- Review employee records for gaps
- Confirm the discipline escalation line (Founder)

Internal Content Team

Described only in the Handbook (\$06, \$29). There is no brief and no incentive entry for it. It markets Brandstro itself (Instagram behind-the-scenes, reels, portfolio, case studies, campaigns, lead-generation experiments) and is judged on consistency and brand-building, not client sign-off.

Creative Head ensures	Content Team Leader owns
A content calendar exists and is followed Direction stays consistent with the agency brand Case studies get made from finished client work QC before anything publishes	Shoot planning and editing workflow Day-to-day posting and scheduling The approval process before publishing

CHAPTER 8

Company-Wide Rules & Standards

Rules that apply across roles. Most of these become validations, required fields or automated alerts in the ERP.

8.1 The client communication rule

Designers, R&D and the Sketch Artist do **not** talk to clients directly unless the CRM or Founder explicitly authorises it for one limited purpose. Any exception is logged. The rule exists to stop conflicting information, unapproved promises and missed instructions [CRM]. The Creative Head also should not take over day-to-day client contact; they join only when a client is unhappy after multiple rounds or there is a major escalation [Handbook §19].

8.2 Response-time SLAs

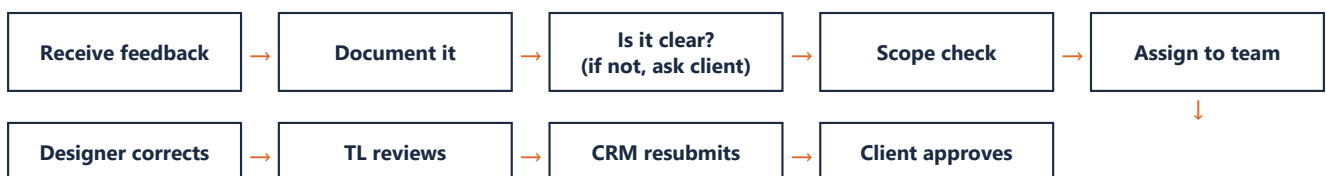
Channel	Standard response time
WhatsApp: active client project	Within 4 business hours
WhatsApp: general enquiry	Within 1 business day
Email	Within 1 business day
Submission acknowledgement	Same business day as receipt from production
Stalled thread / pending approval	Flag to Creative Head after 3+ days unresolved; send the client an update after 3+ days of silence

8.3 Correction or scope change?

Within scope: CRM handles	Scope change: escalate first
Refining an agreed direction (colour, spacing, wording)	A completely different concept after one was approved
Fixing an error in the delivered work	A new deliverable not in the original package
A revision round already included in the package	Revisions beyond the included round count

Never agree to a scope change on the spot. Escalate to Sales/Founder with the request and package details, then tell the client the decision [CRM]. Handbook §25 adds a second distinction for every revision: a **genuine design miss** (fix the thinking) vs **subjective client preference** (fix the brief-gathering).

8.4 The correction loop



8.5 Client complaints



Categories: Delay · Quality · Communication · Scope · Pricing/Payment · Revision · Delivery. **Refund, contract dispute or reputational risk?** Escalate to the Founder before responding [CRM].

8.6 Escalation ladder

Level	Handled by	Typical examples
1: Team-level	Team Leader	Second revision pass, missed internal deadline, one overloaded designer, quality issue at review
2: Cross-team or repeated	Creative Head	The same handoff keeps breaking; the same designer's issue 2+ times; whole team overloaded; client deadline at risk; P1 approval
3: Major business / people / client	Founder	Client threatens to leave or wants a refund; scope/pricing change; payment unresolved after one cycle; serious conduct; formal warnings

Watch out: different level numbers

The Handbook uses 3 levels (TL = 1, Creative Head = 2, Founder = 3). The TL briefs call TL 'L2' and Creative Head 'L3'. The CRM brief calls CRM 'L3' and Founder 'L4'. Same chain, different numbering. The ERP should use named levels (Team / Department / Founder), not numbers.

8.7 WhatsApp vs. the system of record

Happens in WhatsApp	Must also be logged in
Client contact info and meeting notifications	Client Database
Fast client clarification	Client Database: feedback log entry
Any status or deadline change	Project Tracker

'If it isn't also in the Sheet, it's treated as if it never happened: for scope, deadlines and approvals alike.'
[CRM]

8.8 Files, naming and versions

Team	Pattern	Example
Logo	ClientName_Logo_Version_Date	FiltersAndFlavours_Logo_v2_2026-09-06
Packaging	ClientName_DeliverableType_Version_Date	Chaivanth_BrandGuidelines_v3_2026-09-06

- Never overwrite a previous version. Increment v1, v2, v3.
- Working files stay in the designer's working folder and never go directly to a client.
- Only the TL-approved final version goes into **08_Final Files**. Research briefs live in **02_R&D**. Other numbered folders (01, 03–07) are implied but not listed.

8.9 Quality checklists

Logo QC (TL + designer)	Packaging / print-readiness QC (TL + designer)
1 Concept originality and relevance to the brief 2 Typography quality and appropriateness 3 Alignment and proportion 4 Scalability (small and large) + works in black and white 5 Colour accuracy and meaning 6 Presentation quality and correct file exports	1 Brand consistency with approved identity 2 Product / information hierarchy 3 Typography and layout 4 Information accuracy (no factual/spec errors) 5 Correct dimensions for product/material 6 Bleed and safe area applied correctly 7 Mockup quality suitable for client 8 Final artwork print-ready (CMYK, resolution)

The Handbook adds a **7-point Creative Review** before any client presentation: Strategy, Concept, Design, Brand Fit, Distinctiveness, Application, Technical Quality (§28), and an 8-dimension quality lens (§23). See Chapter 10.

8.10 Working time, attendance and leave

- Attendance is logged daily in the Attendance/HR sheet.
- Working week: '5 days — 2nd and 4th Saturdays off, all Sundays off' [HR]. In practice this reads as Monday–Saturday with alternate Saturdays off (see Chapter 13).
- Late arrivals and early departures are logged with a reason. Patterns go to the Founder monthly.
- Discipline: first instance, note it. A repeating pattern, escalate. HR never issues warnings without the Founder knowing.

CHAPTER 9

The Performance Incentive Plan

Base salary is never reduced. On top of it, each person earns a bonus for work beyond their own monthly baseline, paid at a higher rate for clean work (0–1 client revisions).

How it works

- **Baseline:** a number of projects each month that is 'just part of the job'. No bonus, no penalty.
- **Beyond baseline:** real money per project, with the rate set by the **revision tier**: 0–1 revisions (full), 2–3 (half), 4+ (zero; for logos, unless flagged as a client scope change).
- **Individual, not shared:** one person's slow month doesn't wipe out anyone else's bonus. There is no cap on the upside.
- **Team Leaders:** 70% of bonus from the team hitting its target, 30% from their own design work.
- **Quality-tier roles** (Sketch Artist, HR): a flat monthly bonus by percentage band.

Per-role rules (recalculated)

Role	Baseline	Target	Bonus rule	Worked example → earning
R&D	18 concepts	24 concepts	Per concept beyond baseline: ₹350 (0–1 rev), ₹175 (2–3), ₹0 (4+), judged on the downstream design's revisions	5 clean + 1 partial = ₹1,925 → ₹11,925 (plan rounds to ₹12,000)
Sketch Artist	—	24 sketches (full capacity)	% of sketches the Logo Team completes with no rework: ≥90% ₹5,000 · 75–89% ₹3,000 · 60–74% ₹1,500 · below 60% ₹0	22/24 = 91% → ₹15,000
Logo Designer (×3)	4 logos	7 logos	Per logo beyond baseline: ₹1,650 (0–1), ₹825 (2–3), ₹0 (4+ unless scope change)	3 clean = ₹4,950 → ₹14,950 (≈ ₹15,000)
Logo Team Leader	Personal 2 logos	Team 21 logos + personal 4	Team (70%): up to ₹3,500 if all 3 designers hit 7 with healthy revision rate. Personal (30%): ₹750 per clean logo beyond 2, max ₹1,500	₹3,500 + ₹1,500 → ₹17,000
Packaging Designer (×3)	1 branding set, 1 label, 1 pack	5 branding, 4 labels, 2 packs	Beyond each baseline: Branding ₹700/350/0 · Label ₹450/225/0 · Packaging ₹900/450/0	2,800 + 1,350 + 900 = ₹5,050 → base + ~5,000
Packaging Team Leader	Personal small baseline	Team 15 branding + 12 label + 6 pack; personal 1 + 3 + 2	Team (70%) up to ₹3,500; personal (30%) up to ₹1,500	₹17,000
CRM	—	42 of ~47 projects	₹240 per project closed with 0–1 revisions and full 50/50 payment collected on time	42 × 240 = ₹10,080 → ₹20,080 (≈ ₹20,000)
HR / PA	—	11 of 12 team members hit their own target	11–12: ₹5,000 · 9–10: ₹3,000 · 7–8: ₹1,500 · below 7: ₹0	→ ₹15,000

Does the capacity add up?

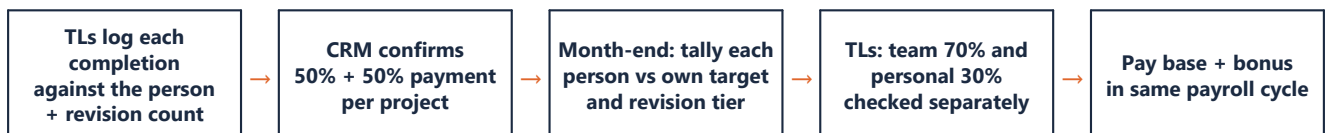
Output	Company target	Covered by	Check
Sketches	24	Sketch Artist 24	Exactly at capacity. No slack.
Logos (logo-only + branding)	24	3 designers × 7 + TL 4 = 25	OK (+1 spare)
Branding collateral sets	16	3 × 5 + TL 1 = 16	Exact
Standalone labels	15	3 × 4 + TL 3 = 15	Exact
Standalone packaging	8	3 × 2 + TL 2 = 8	Exact
CRM clean closes	~47 projects	42 target	Allows ~5 slips

Company economics at full target

Line item	Amount
Revenue (8 logo, 16 branding, 15 label, 8 packaging)	₹3,53,500
Fixed payroll	– ₹1,26,000
Bonus payout, everyone at target	– ₹61,900
Rent, software, electricity, misc.	– ₹17,000
Company profit	₹1,48,600 (42.0% margin)

Recomputing the bonuses from the per-role examples gives ₹62,005 (R&D 1,925 + Sketch 5,000 + Logo 3 × 4,950 + Logo TL 5,000 + Packaging 3 × 5,050 + Pack TL 5,000 + CRM 10,080 + HR 5,000), within ₹105 of the plan's ₹61,900. The difference is rounding in the plan. The ERP should compute the exact figures.

Monthly procedure (from the plan)



ERP note: data the incentive engine needs

Per completed deliverable: the **credited person**, deliverable type (logo / branding set / label / packaging / R&D concept / sketch), completion date, **client revision count**, whether revisions were flagged as **client scope change**, 'needed rework' flag (for Sketch), and payment status.

Per person per month: baseline and target per work type, rate table by tier, role formula (per-unit, tiered %, or 70/30 team split). All configurable, never hard-coded.

CHAPTER 10

The Creative Head's Management System

The 70-page Handbook, condensed. It is a coaching curriculum (read section by section with the Founder), but it also defines the reviews, metrics, meetings and scorecards the ERP should make easy.

Structure of the Handbook

Part	Sections	Theme
1 The Role	01–06	From performer to multiplier; mission; what the role is NOT; authority layers; the agency's teams
2 Leading the Leaders	07–16	Weekly TL review, performance framework, underperformance, problem-solving, conflict, delegation, feedback, culture
3 Running the Department	17–22	Capacity and workload, cross-team handoffs, client involvement, QC, training, leadership pipeline
4 Branding-Agency Leadership	23–30	Judging creative quality, the 8-stage process, revision management, briefs, creative review, content team, dashboard
5 Operating Discipline	31–41	Daily/weekly/monthly rhythm, meetings, decisions, escalation, accountability, EQ, mistakes, systems
6 First 90 Days	42	Understand (1–30) → Improve (31–60) → Scale (61–90)
7 Practice	43–45	16 real office scenarios, self-reflection questions, 13-category scorecard
8 Partnership	46–49	Founder relationship, success definition, 20 principles, signed commitment

Each Part ends with discussion pages (Founder's notes, Creative Head's notes, key agreements, action items with owner / deadline / review date).

Weekly Team Leader Review: 8 questions (\$07)

Area	Question
Output	What did your team finish this week, and what's still open?
Quality	What needed rework, and why?
Deadlines	What's at risk in the next seven days?
Client blockers	What's waiting on a client response or approval?
Discipline & morale	Anything you're worried about with a specific person?
Bottlenecks	Where did work sit idle, and why?
Resourcing	Do you have enough people for what's coming next week?
Improvement action	What's one thing you'll do differently next week?

Performance framework (\$08–09)

Nine dimensions: output, quality, timeliness, consistency, efficiency, improvement, accountability, collaboration, problem-solving. **Scorecard KPIs:** tasks assigned vs completed, on-time completion %, revision rounds per project, rework hours, escalations, client-facing errors. KPIs are for spotting where coaching is needed, not for catching people out.

Underperformance in 8 steps: Identify → Measure → Diagnose → Coach → Improvement plan → Timeline → Review → Escalate. Causes to check: workload, skill gap, unclear brief or standard, lack of training, poor management above, personal issues, process problem, wrong role.

Problem-solving and conflict (§10–11)

Use the **5 Whys** to find the root cause. The Handbook's example: a packaging job was 3 days late because the designer waited on R&D, R&D wasn't told it was urgent, and there was no shared deadline view. Root cause: **no one owns a visible cross-team tracker**. Record: Problem → Cause → Solution → Owner → Deadline → Review.

Conflict path: Listen → Understand → Separate facts from feelings → Root cause → Decide → Communicate → Follow up. Praise publicly, correct privately.

Delegation, communication, feedback (§12–15)

- Delegation record: Task, Owner, Expected result, Deadline, Authority, Checkpoint.
- **SBI** for feedback (Situation, Behaviour, Impact). **CLEAR** for instructions (Context, Expectation, Action, Deadline, Review).
- Feedback types: positive, corrective, performance, leadership, difficult.

Workload and capacity tools to introduce (§17–18)

Tool	Answers
Capacity Planning	Given today's team, how many projects can realistically start this week?
Workload Dashboard	Who is overloaded, who has room, right now?
Priority Matrix	Urgent-and-important vs important-not-urgent
Daily Task Review	Is today's plan still realistic by lunchtime?
Weekly Capacity Review	Are we about to overcommit next week?
Shared status view	Project, current owner, days-to-deadline. 'Who has this right now' should never need asking.

Creative quality lens (§23) and 7-point review (§28)

Quality dimension (§23)	Ask
Concept strength	A real idea, or just decoration?
Strategic relevance	Fits the brand's positioning?
Distinctiveness	Stands out next to five competitors?
Simplicity & memorability	Describable after one look?
Scalability	Works as a favicon and a shopfront sign?
Typography & colour	Deliberate or default?
Application	Works on packaging, stationery, t-shirt?
Technical execution	Production-ready file?

7-point pre-presentation review: **Strategy · Concept · Design · Brand Fit · Distinctiveness · Application · Technical Quality**.

Revision management (§25) and brief quality (§27)

- Track four things: revision rate by project type, first-presentation approval share, revision root cause (design miss vs preference), recurring client feedback patterns.
- Current pattern: some clients approve the first draft; 'fine' clients need about 2 corrections; a few need 3+; very few need 5+.
- The ₹15,000 branding package has sold with **informally unlimited revisions** for some clients. That is a margin problem: 5 rounds consume time priced for 2.

- **Briefing checklist:** brand in one sentence, target audience, positioning, business objective, what to communicate/avoid, competitors, exact deliverables and deadline, what the client expects to see first, reference direction / constraints. Missing items are flagged [CLIENT INPUT REQUIRED].

Performance dashboard (§30)

Area	Track
Production	Projects received, completed, in progress, pending, delayed
Logo / Identity	Concepts completed, first-presentation quality, revision rounds, turnaround time
Packaging	Concepts completed, revision rounds, turnaround time, technical errors caught
R&D	Concepts/research delivered, support requests, turnaround time
Internal Content	Content planned vs produced vs published, pending items
People	Attendance, productivity, training progress, leadership development

Operating rhythm and meetings (§31–32)

Meeting	Length	Purpose
Daily leadership check-in	10–15 min	Surface today's risks
Weekly Team Leader meeting	30–45 min	The 8-question review
Monthly department review	60 min	Trends, scorecard, next month's priorities
One-to-one employee review	15–20 min	Individual development
Performance improvement meeting	As needed	§09 framework
Problem-solving meeting	As needed	§10 framework
Post-project review	15 min	What worked / didn't on a finished project

Every meeting ends with action items that have an owner and a date. 'A meeting without an action item was a conversation, not a decision.'

Decisions, mistakes, accountability (§33–41)

- **Decide alone** when it's within one team, reversible, and within authority. **Consult TLs** when it changes how a team works or sets a precedent. **Founder** when it changes pricing, scope, a client relationship, hiring/firing, major spend, or involves serious repeated people problems.
- Accountability record: What? Who? When? Expected standard? Current status? Next action?
- Mistake types and responses: honest (fix, note the pattern), repeated negligence (documented conversation), skill gap (training), attention gap (find the cause), intentional misconduct (Founder).
- Recurring problem → build a system (checklist, dashboard, approval step, training module, escalation rule).

30 / 60 / 90 days (§42)

Days 1–30: Understand	Days 31–60: Improve	Days 61–90: Scale
Learn how work flows across all four teams Sit with each TL Map problems (start with Packaging) Set baseline KPIs	Fix top problems Start structured TL coaching Introduce weekly review and shared status view Close the missing client sign-off step	Standardise what worked First leadership pipeline Sustainable daily/weekly/monthly rhythm Report changes to Founder with numbers

16 real scenarios (\$43), in short

#	Situation	Strong move
1	Packaging misses another deadline	Run 5 Whys with the TL; fix capacity, handoff or skill, not just this project
2	Designer argues with TL in public	Separate them, hear both privately, coach the TL on de-escalation
3	TL great at craft, poor with people	Name it; coach specific leadership behaviours
4	One designer far outperforms	Recognise; learn what they do differently; don't overload them
5	Talented but undisciplined designer	Same standard as everyone
6	Designer escalates small issues to you	Redirect to TL; tell the TL
7	Client revision spike mid-project	Check brief miss vs scope creep; involve CRM
8	30 clients, capacity for 6–8	Capacity plan, realistic timelines, flag the mismatch to Founder with numbers
9	One team idle, another buried	Use the shared status view to redistribute or cross-train
10	TL hides a team problem	Address privately; it's about trust
11	Unfair workload complaint	Check the workload dashboard before responding
12	High performer turns arrogant	Address the behaviour directly
13	Junior shows leadership potential	Give small ownership now
14	Same packaging mistake keeps recurring	3+ times = system gap; add it to the checklist
15	Deadline tomorrow, work incomplete	Assess honestly; warn client early; then assign
16	Founder gets a quality complaint	Investigate; bring cause and fix, not excuses

Monthly scorecard (\$45)

Rated 1–5 with the Founder: Overall team performance · Team Leader development · Productivity · Quality · Deadline management · Problem solving · Employee development · Communication · Discipline & culture · Process improvement · Cross-team coordination · Leadership pipeline · Strategic thinking. (1 = urgent attention, 3 = meeting the bar, 5 = a model for other leaders.)

How to bring problems to the Founder (\$46)

Problem + Analysis + Options + Recommendation. Not just 'Packaging is behind again.'

CHAPTER 11

Today's Tools → What the ERP Replaces

Brandstro currently runs on Google Drive, Google Sheets and WhatsApp. These are the tools the documents mention, and what each becomes.

Current tool	Used by	Holds	Becomes in the ERP
WhatsApp: Leads group	Founder, CRM	Incoming enquiries	Leads module (optionally WhatsApp Business API intake)
WhatsApp: Client Meetings group	CRM, team	Meeting notifications, quick clarifications	Meeting scheduler + client communication log; WhatsApp stays as a notification channel
Client Database (sheet)	CRM	Client info, feedback log	Clients, Contacts, Feedback entities
Project Tracker (sheet)	All	Status, deadlines, handoffs, timestamps, revisions	Projects / Deliverables / Stage history (auto-timestamped)
Team Task Tracker (sheet)	TLs, designers	Assignments, load, deadlines	Task board + workload view per designer
QC checklist logs	TLs, designers	Review outcomes	Checklist records attached to each review
Attendance / HR sheet	HR	Attendance, leave balances	HR module: attendance, leave, holiday calendar
Google Drive project folders (02_R&D ... 08_Final Files)	All	Briefs, working files, finals	Keep Drive for files; ERP stores links, versions and enforces naming
Sales handover notes	Founder → CRM	Package, price, promises	Order record with a required handover section
Monthly review packs	Founder, Creative Head	Summaries, scorecards	Generated dashboards and reports

Recommendation

Don't try to replace Drive file storage or WhatsApp chat. Replace the **sheets** and connect to the other two: store Drive links and versions, and send WhatsApp/email notifications from the ERP. That matches the rule 'WhatsApp for speed, the sheet for the record'.

CHAPTER 12

ERP Blueprint

A proposed design derived from the documents. Everything here traces back to a rule in Chapters 4–10. Where the documents are silent, the choice is marked as a recommendation.

12.1 Modules

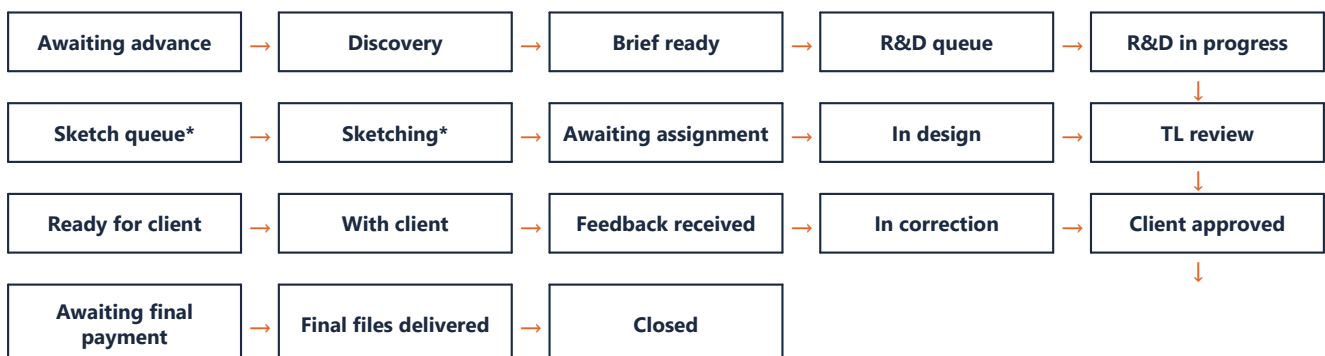
#	Module	Covers	Primary users
1	Sales & Leads	Leads, quotes, orders, packages sold, handover notes	Founder
2	Clients (CRM)	Client database, contacts, onboarding checklist, discovery notes, communication log, SLA timers	CRM
3	Projects & Workflow	Projects, deliverables, route (with/without sketch), stage transitions, handoff acknowledgement	All
4	Briefs	Project Brief (CRM), briefing checklist with [CLIENT INPUT REQUIRED] flags, R&D research brief template	CRM, R&D
5	Queues & Assignment	R&D and Sketch queues (P1/P2/P3, FIFO by payment date), TL assignment by load	R&D, Sketch, TLs
6	Design Production	Tasks, file versions (Drive links), naming validation, mockups	Designers, TLs
7	Quality Control	Logo QC, Packaging/print QC, Sketch self-check, 7-point creative review; pass/rework log	TLs, Creative Head
8	Feedback, Revisions & Approvals	Feedback log, revision rounds, scope classification, scope-change approval, client sign-off	CRM, TLs, Founder
9	Complaints	Categorised complaints, root cause, resolution, escalation	CRM, Founder
10	Billing & Payments	Advance/final invoices, receipts, follow-ups, release gate for final files	CRM, HR/Accounts, Founder
11	HR	Employees, attendance, leave, discipline log, onboarding/exit checklists, work calendar	HR
12	Performance & Incentives	Targets, baselines, rate tables, completions, monthly bonus calculation, payroll export	Founder, HR
13	Leadership & Reviews	Weekly TL review form, action items, improvement plans, 1:1s, monthly scorecard, 90-day plan	Creative Head, Founder
14	Dashboards & Reports	Department dashboard, capacity/workload, SLA, revision analytics, profitability	Founder, Creative Head, TLs
15	Internal Content	Content calendar, planned/produced/published, approvals, case-study pipeline	Content TL, Creative Head
16	Notifications	WhatsApp/email/in-app alerts, escalation rules	System

12.2 Core entities and key fields

Entity	Key fields
Employee	name, role, team, reports_to, base_salary, join_date, status, access flags
Team	name (Logo / Packaging / R&D-Sketch / Content), leader_id
Product / Package	name, base_price, additional_unit_price, included_deliverables[], included_revision_rounds, route_template
Lead	source, contact, interest, status, owner (Founder)
Client	business name, contacts, industry, onboarding checklist state, notes
Order	client, package(s), agreed price, discount, promises_made, handover_notes, sold_by, sold_on
Invoice / Payment	order, milestone (advance / final), amount, due_date, paid_on, follow_up_count
Project	order, route (with sketch / direct / designer-originated), priority P1/P2/P3, payment_confirmed_on (queue order), client_deadline, current_stage, current_owner, crm_owner
Deliverable	project, type (logo, guideline book, visiting card, letterhead, t-shirt, label, packaging), team, assignee, status, revision_count, internal_rework_count, credited_to
Brief	project, type (project brief / research brief), sections (6-part template), missing_inputs[], file_link, completed_on
Handoff	project, from_owner, to_owner, sent_at, acknowledged_at
File Version	deliverable, version_no, file_name (validated), drive_link, is_final, approved_by
QC Review	deliverable, checklist_type, item results, outcome (pass / rework), reviewer, reviewed_at
Client Feedback	deliverable, received_at, channel, text, is_clear, classification (in-scope / scope change), root cause (design miss / preference), round_no
Scope Change Request	project, description, escalated_to, decision, price_change, decided_at
Approval / Sign-off	deliverable or project, approved_by_client_at, evidence (message/screenshot link)
Complaint	client, project, category (7), severity, root cause, resolution, escalated flag
Attendance / Leave	employee, date, status, in/out, late reason; leave type, dates, approver, balance
Discipline Note	employee, date, type, pattern_flag, founder_informed
Incentive Plan	role, period, baselines per work type, target, rate table by revision tier, formula type (per-unit / tiered % / team 70-30)
Monthly Incentive Result	employee, month, counts per tier, bonus, approved_by, paid_in_payroll
Action Item	source meeting/review, description, owner, deadline, review_date, status

12.3 Deliverable status workflow

Recommendation: track status on each **deliverable**, and derive the project's status from them. A branding package has a logo in the Logo Team and four or five collateral pieces in the Packaging Team at once, so one project-level status can't show where the work actually is.



* Only for routes that use the sketch step. Side states: **Rework** (TL review failed → back to In design), **Scope change pending** (feedback classified as scope change → Founder decision), **On hold** (waiting on client input), **Cancelled**.

Transition rules (guards)

Transition	Allowed only if	Source
→ R&D queue	Advance payment recorded; brief has no unresolved [CLIENT INPUT REQUIRED] (or override logged)	[CRM][R&D][Handbook §27]
R&D → next stage	Research brief complete (all 6 sections) + file in 02_R&D + next owner acknowledged	[R&D]
→ Ready for client	QC review with outcome = pass by the team's TL	[LogoTL][PackTL]
→ With client	Performed by CRM only	[CRM]
Feedback → In correction	Classified as in-scope and revision round ≤ package limit; otherwise → Scope change pending	[CRM]
In correction → Ready for client	TL re-review passed (packaging: fresh print-readiness check if dimensions/bleed/artwork changed)	[PackDes][PackTL]
→ Client approved	Sign-off evidence recorded	[CRM]
→ Final files delivered	Final payment recorded; file marked final and in 08_Final Files	[Handbook §24][LogoDes]
P1 priority set	Approved by Founder/Creative Head; no other P1 active in that queue	[R&D]

12.4 Roles and permissions (summary)

Capability	Founder	Creative Head	CRM	TL	Designer	R&D / Sketch	HR
Create leads/orders, set price and discount	Yes	—	View	—	—	—	—
Client database and client messages	Yes	View	Yes	View	—	—	—
Set priority P1	Yes	Yes	Request	—	—	—	—
Assign work within team	—	Yes	—	Own team	—	—	—
Upload versions / submit to TL	—	—	—	Yes	Yes	Yes	—
QC pass / rework	—	Yes	—	Own team	—	—	—
Submit to client, log feedback, sign-off	Yes	—	Yes	—	—	—	—
Approve scope change / extra revisions	Yes	Extra revisions	Escalate	Escalate	—	—	—
Record payments	Yes	—	Yes	—	—	—	Accounts
Attendance and leave	View all	View	Self	Approve team	Self	Self	Manage
Discipline notes / warnings	Issue	View	—	—	—	—	Log only
Incentive results	Approve	View dept	Self	Team + self	Self	Self	Prepare

12.5 Automations and alerts

Trigger	Action	Source rule
Client message on active project unanswered 4 business hours (1 day for enquiry/email)	Alert CRM; SLA breach logged	[CRM] SLAs
Production marks 'Ready for client' and no submission by end of day	Alert CRM	[CRM] same-day acknowledgement
Client thread silent or approval pending 3+ days	Prompt CRM to send update; weekly flag to Creative Head	[CRM]
Handoff not acknowledged within X hours	Alert sender and receiver; stage treated as not started	[R&D]
Days-to-deadline below threshold and stage not advanced	Deadline-risk flag on dashboard; notify TL, then Creative Head	[Handbook §18][LogoTL]
Revision round exceeds package limit	Block auto-assignment; require scope decision	[CRM][Handbook §25]
Same designer fails QC 2+ times on the same issue	Escalate to Creative Head	[LogoTL][PackTL]
Same QC failure item 3+ times across the team	Suggest adding to the checklist (system gap)	[Handbook §43 #14]
Final payment outstanding after one follow-up cycle	Escalate to Founder	[CRM]
Unapproved absence	Same-day flag to HR and TL; repeat → Founder	[HR]
Leave approved during active deadlines	Coverage-gap alert to TL	[HR]
Designer queue much longer than peers	Rebalance suggestion to TL	[LogoTL][PackTL]
Month end	Compute incentive results for approval	[Incentive]

12.6 Dashboards

- **Founder:** sales vs 47-engagement target by product, revenue, receivables, margin estimate, escalations, complaints.
- **Creative Head:** §30 dashboard (production, per-team metrics, people), capacity vs demand for next week, deadline-risk list, first-presentation approval rate, revision root causes.
- **Team Leader:** designer workload, QC pass rate, overdue items, team progress to monthly target (the 70% component).
- **CRM:** open threads with SLA clocks, pending approvals, payments due, clean-close count toward 42.
- **Individual:** my queue, my deadlines, my progress to baseline and target, my projected bonus.
- **HR:** attendance today, leave calendar, coverage gaps, team members on track for target (HR bonus metric).

12.7 Incentive engine formulas

Formula type	Roles	Calculation
Per-unit, tiered by revisions	R&D, Logo Designer, Packaging Designer	For each work type: units beyond baseline, taken in completion order → rate[tier(revisions)]. Tier: 0–1 full · 2–3 half · 4+ zero (logo 4+ counts as full or half if flagged as client scope change; the rule needs confirming). Sum over work types.
Quality band	Sketch Artist	pct = sketches with no rework ÷ sketches delivered → band bonus (90/75/60)
Team 70 / personal 30	Logo TL, Packaging TL	team_part = 3,500 if every designer hits target and team revision rate is 'healthy' (threshold needs defining); personal_part = rate × clean units beyond personal baseline, capped at 1,500
Per clean close	CRM	240 × projects with ≤1 revision AND both payments collected on time
Team attainment band	HR / PA	count of the 12 who hit their own target → band bonus (11/9/7)

Question the engine must settle

Which units count as 'beyond baseline' when a person completes, say, 7 logos with mixed revision counts? The plan's examples assume the extra ones are the clean ones. Recommendation: count in completion order and show the rule on each person's dashboard so nobody is surprised.

12.8 Suggested build phases

Phase	Scope	Why first
1: Core record (4–6 weeks)	Employees/roles, clients, orders, projects/deliverables, stage workflow, handoffs, Drive links, file naming, basic dashboard	Replaces the Project Tracker, the most-referenced tool. Answers 'who has this right now?'
2: Quality and client loop	QC checklists, feedback log, revision counting, scope-change approval, sign-off, SLA timers, payments with release gate	Produces the revision and payment data the incentives depend on
3: People and money	Attendance, leave, discipline, incentive engine, payroll export	Needs 1 month of clean phase-2 data to be trustworthy
4: Leadership layer	Weekly TL review forms, action items, scorecards, capacity planning, revision analytics, content calendar	Turns the Handbook into routine

CHAPTER 13

Gaps, Contradictions & Open Questions

Places where the ten documents disagree, or where the ERP needs a rule nobody has written down yet. Settle these with the Founder before building the affected module.

#	Issue	Where	Why it matters for the ERP / question for the Founder
1	Master SOP referenced (sections 6–38) but not provided	All briefs	May define packages, revision limits, folders, payment terms. Ask for it.
2	Logo Team size: 4 designers vs 3	LogoTL vs Incentive	Capacity, targets and payroll change. Confirm the real headcount.
3	Creative Head not in payroll, bonus plan or profit maths	Incentive vs Handbook	Is the Creative Head a separate salary (profit falls) or combined with a TL role?
4	Internal Content Team has no brief, no headcount, no incentive	Handbook only	Is it staffed? Should the ERP include the content module now?
5	Included revision rounds per package never stated; branding 'informally unlimited' for some	CRM vs Handbook \$25	Needed to detect scope creep automatically. Define N per package.
6	Label/Packaging price '(1st)': price for additional units unknown	Incentive	Needed for quoting and invoices.
7	CRM scope: brief says escalate pricing/discounts; Incentive says CRM 'closes deals' and collects payments	CRM vs Incentive	Can the CRM create orders or change prices? Sets permissions.
8	HR scope: brief = HR/Admin; Incentive = HR/Personal Assistant with accounts and oversight of CRM/TLs	HR vs Incentive	Does HR get finance and project-oversight access?
9	Escalation levels numbered differently (1–3, L2–L3, L3–L4)	Handbook vs briefs	Use named levels.
10	Working week: '5 days' but only 2nd/4th Saturdays off; Sketch capacity assumes 24 days, Packaging maths assumes 21 days/person	HR vs Incentive	Define the working-day calendar once; capacity and SLAs ('business hours') depend on it.
11	Business hours for the 4-hour SLA not defined	CRM	Needed to compute SLA timers.
12	R&D benchmark 2 briefs/day (~48/month) vs incentive target 24 'concepts'	R&D vs Incentive	Does a 'concept' count only logo/branding briefs, or packaging research too?
13	Sketch step sometimes skipped / designer-originated concepts	Handbook \$18, \$24	Route must be selectable per project; who gets R&D/Sketch credit then?
14	Branding package: collateral in parallel with the logo, or after logo approval?	Not stated	Drives the workflow dependency between the two teams.
15	'Healthy team-wide revision rate' for the TL bonus not quantified	Incentive	Needs a number (e.g. average ≤ 1.5 rounds).
16	Logo 4+ revisions pay zero 'unless flagged as client scope change'. The pay rate in that case isn't stated; other roles don't have the exception.	Incentive	Define the rule and who can set the flag.
17	Who records 'no rework' for the Sketch Artist bonus	Incentive	Probably Logo TL. Add a field at design start.
18	Drive folder structure only partly known (02_R&D, 08_Final Files)	Briefs	Need the full 01–08 list to generate folders automatically.
19	No formal client sign-off existed before (Handbook); the CRM brief now requires it	Handbook \$24 vs CRM	Make sign-off a mandatory step with evidence.

#	Issue	Where	Why it matters for the ERP / question for the Founder
20	Intake exceeded capacity (30 clients vs 6–8 done)	Handbook §17	Sales should see capacity before promising start dates. Add a capacity check to order creation.

Suggested next step

Take this table into one 60-minute session with the Founder. Items 2, 3, 5, 7, 10 and 14 affect the data model and should be settled before Phase 1. The rest can be settled during Phases 2–3.

CHAPTER 14

Glossary & Numbers Cheat-Sheet

Glossary

Term	Meaning at Brandstro
CRM	Client Relationship Manager: the person (not software) who is the only link to clients
TL	Team Leader (Logo TL, Packaging TL)
Creative Head	Leader of the Team Leaders; owns department performance
R&D	Research & creative direction role; produces the research brief
Research brief	R&D's 6-section structured output: overview, audience, competitors, positioning, visual direction, include/avoid
Project Brief	CRM's requirement summary handed to R&D after discovery
Concept set	The Sketch Artist's 3–5 distinct sketch directions for one logo
Branding package	₹15,000 product: logo + guideline book, visiting card, letterhead, t-shirt, packaging
Correction / revision	A client-requested change within the agreed direction; counted in rounds
Rework	Internal: TL sends work back before it reaches the client
Scope change	New concept after approval, new deliverable, or rounds beyond the package. Founder decides.
Clean	Completed with 0–1 client revisions (full bonus rate)
Baseline	Monthly units that are part of the job (no bonus)
P1 / P2 / P3	Queue priorities: urgent (one at a time) / standard FIFO by payment / work-ahead
Print-ready	Correct dimensions, bleed, safe area, CMYK, resolution
08_Final Files	Drive folder for TL-approved finals only
SBI / CLEAR	Feedback model (Situation-Behaviour-Impact) / instruction model (Context-Expectation-Action-Deadline-Review)
Handoff	Moving ownership to the next stage; incomplete until acknowledged

Numbers cheat-sheet

Number	Meaning
₹6,000 / ₹15,000 / ₹2,500 / ₹3,500	Logo / Branding package / Label (1st) / Packaging (1st)
8 / 16 / 15 / 8 = 47	Monthly sales target by product
₹3,53,500	Monthly revenue target
50% + 50%	Advance before work; balance before final files
24	Sketches per month (company-wide ceiling for logo + branding)
2 / 1 / 1 / 1	Daily benchmarks: R&D briefs / sketch sets / logos per designer / packaging designs per designer
3–5	Distinct sketch concepts per logo; competitor references in a research brief
4 hrs / 1 day / same day	CRM SLAs: active WhatsApp / enquiry & email / submission acknowledgement
3+ days	Stalled client thread → update client, flag to Creative Head
2+ times	Same designer's quality issue → escalate to Creative Head
3+ times	Same mistake across the team → treat as a system gap
0–1 / 2–3 / 4+	Revision tiers: full / half / zero bonus
70 / 30	TL bonus split: team / personal
₹1,26,000 / ₹61,900 / ₹17,000	Payroll / full bonus / overheads per month
~42%	Margin at full target (required 40–50%)
1 day	Minimum notice for planned leave
2nd & 4th Saturday, all Sundays	Days off

PART B

Appendix: Original Documents

The ten source PDFs follow, unchanged, in the order below. Each one is also bookmarked in the PDF sidebar.

Original document	Pages	Starts on page
Creative Head Leadership Handbook	70	45
Performance Incentive Plan	13	115
CRM Brief	3	128
HR / Admin Brief	3	131
R&D Brief	3	134
Sketch Artist Brief	3	137
Logo Team Leader Brief	3	140
Logo Designer Brief	3	143
Packaging Team Leader Brief	3	146
Packaging Designer Brief	3	149

Page numbers are positions in this combined file. The original documents keep their own internal page numbering.

The Overall Creative Head *Handbook.*

A working curriculum for the leader who now owns the performance of Logo, Packaging, R&D and Internal Content — built to be read aloud, one section at a time, with the Founder in the room.

Contents

Forty-nine sections, eight parts. Work through them in order — each one is a conversation, not a memo.

PART ONE — THE ROLE

- 01 Context of the Role
- 02 From Performer to Multiplier
- 03 Role Mission
- 04 What This Role Is Not
- 05 Authority & Reporting Structure
- 06 The Agency You're Leading

PART TWO — LEADING THE LEADERS

- 07 You Are Now a Leader of Leaders
- 08 Performance Management Framework
- 09 Handling Underperforming Employees
- 10 Problem-Solving Framework
- 11 Handling Team Conflict
- 12 Delegation
- 13 Micromanagement vs Leadership
- 14 Communication
- 15 How to Give Feedback
- 16 Team Culture

PART THREE — RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

- 17 Productivity & Workload Management
- 18 Cross-Team Coordination
- 19 Client Involvement
- 20 Quality Control
- 21 Training & Development
- 22 Leadership Pipeline

PART FOUR — LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

- 23 Evaluating Creative Quality

- 24 Creative Process Management
- 25 Revision Management
- 26 Creative vs Commercial Thinking
- 27 Brief Quality
- 28 Creative Review System
- 29 Managing the Internal Content Team
- 30 Branding-Agency Performance Dashboard

Contents, continued

PART FIVE — OPERATING DISCIPLINE

- 31 Daily / Weekly / Monthly Responsibilities
- 32 Meeting Structures
- 33 Decision-Making
- 34 Escalation Management
- 35 Accountability
- 36 Emotional Intelligence
- 37 Leadership Character
- 38 Trust & Authority
- 39 Handling Mistakes
- 40 Building Systems
- 41 Continuous Improvement & Growth Mindset

PART SIX — THE FIRST 90 DAYS

- 42 The 30 / 60 / 90-Day Plan

PART SEVEN — PRACTICE

- 43 Real Office Scenarios
- 44 Leadership Self-Reflection Questions
- 45 The Leader's Monthly Scorecard

PART EIGHT — PARTNERSHIP & CLOSE

- 46 Founder ↔ Creative Head Working Relationship
- 47 What Success Looks Like
- 48 Final Leadership Principles
- 49 My Leadership Commitment

HOW TO USE THIS HANDBOOK

Read one section. Discuss the examples. Fill in the notes together. Agree on actions before moving to the next page.

SIX SECTIONS

The Role

What you're actually being asked to do — and, just as importantly, what you're being asked to stop doing.

-
- 01 Context of the Role
 - 02 From Performer to Multiplier
 - 03 Role Mission
 - 04 What This Role Is Not
 - 05 Authority & Reporting Structure
 - 06 The Agency You're Leading

01

PART ONE – THE ROLE

Context of the Role

You've been given authority over something bigger than a team. You've been given authority over how every team performs.

Brandstro now runs several creative functions that each need to work well on their own, and work well together: the **Logo / Brand Identity Team**, the **Packaging Team, R&D and Sketch**, and the **Internal Content Creation Team**. Each of these has, or will have, its own Team Leader running day-to-day work.

You are being placed above the individual Team Leaders — not as a bigger Team Leader yourself, but as the person responsible for the performance, discipline, development, coordination, productivity and growth of the whole creative ecosystem.

YOU ARE NOT

- The person who personally executes every design task.
- Expected to micromanage individual designers.
- Primarily responsible for client servicing.

YOU ARE

- Responsible for making Team Leaders better at leading.
- Responsible for making teams better at producing.
- Responsible for building the systems that make performance repeatable — not dependent on any one person's mood or memory.
- Responsible for catching problems before they become client-facing emergencies.

Why you, and why now

You led the Logo Team when it was underperforming, and you turned it around. That is the exact evidence the Founder is promoting on — not your personal design output, but proof that you can change how a group of people performs. The Packaging Team has real, current problems: missed deadlines, inconsistent quality, unclear ownership between managing and designing. Your job is **not** to become the new Packaging Team Leader and fix it by hand. Your job is to work with the Packaging Team Leader so the team fixes itself — and stays fixed after you've moved your attention elsewhere.

HOLD ONTO THIS

The Logo Team improved because you were close to it every day. The next test is whether Packaging, R&D and Content can improve without you being close to them every day.

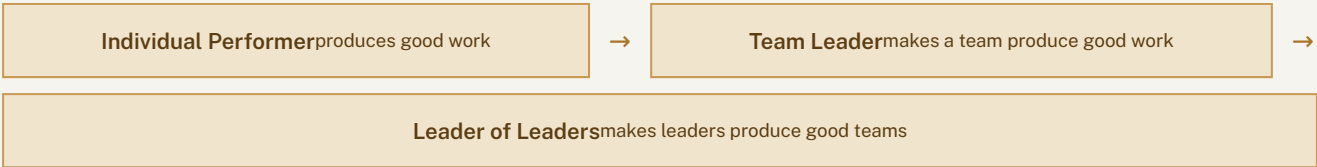
02

PART ONE – THE ROLE

From Performer to Multiplier

Your job is no longer to be the best individual performer. Your job is to make the entire team perform better.

Every creative career moves through the same three stages, and each stage rewards a different kind of thinking. Confusing the stages is the single most common reason a good promotion goes badly.



LEVEL	MEASURED BY	MAIN RISK IF STUCK AT THE WRONG LEVEL
Individual Performer	Quality of your own logos, packs, sketches	You stay valuable, but the agency stays capped at what you can personally touch.
Team Leader	Whether your team hits quality and deadlines without you doing the work yourself	You become a bottleneck — the team can't move faster than you can review.
Leader of Leaders	Whether your Team Leaders are becoming stronger, independent decision-makers	You quietly become an over-qualified Packaging Team Leader instead of a Creative Head.

Notice what changes at each step: an Individual Performer is judged on output. A Team Leader is judged on their team's output. You will be judged on whether the *Team Leaders* — including the one running Packaging right now — are getting better at running their teams. That is a different skill from being a strong designer, and it is the one this handbook trains.

HOLD ONTO THIS

A strong individual contributor produces good work. A strong Team Leader makes their team produce good work. A strong Creative Head makes Team Leaders become stronger leaders.

03

PART ONE – THE ROLE

Role Mission

One sentence the Founder should be able to hold you to, every month.

MISSION STATEMENT

I own the health and performance of the overall creative department — the strength of its Team Leaders, the productivity, quality and accountability of every team, and the systems that let it grow without breaking. Each Team Leader still owns their own team.

That single sentence expands into fourteen concrete ownership areas. Use this list as a checklist, not as decoration — if you can't point to evidence for a row, that's a gap to close this month.

OWNERSHIP AREA	WHAT "GOOD" LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE
Team performance	Every team hits agreed output and quality, most months, without heroics.
Team Leader development	Leaders can diagnose their own team's problems before you point them out.
Employee development	Every employee has a named next skill they're working on.
Productivity	Workload matches capacity; nobody is silently overloaded or idle.
Quality	First-presentation work is strong enough that revisions are the exception.
Accountability	When something slips, the reason is known — not guessed at.
Problem-solving	Recurring problems get systems, not repeated pep talks.
Process improvement	The workflow gets a little better every month, not just when something breaks.
Capacity planning	You can say, today, whether the team can take on ten more logo projects this week.
Work allocation	Work goes to the right person for the right reason, not whoever is least busy.
Team culture	People take ownership without being told, and admit mistakes without fear.
Performance tracking	You can show trends, not just this week's snapshot.
Conflict management	Disagreements get resolved, not avoided or escalated by default.
Leadership pipeline	You already know who could run a team next, before you need them to.

04

PART ONE — THE ROLE

What You Are NOT Here to Do

Leadership is leverage. Every hour you spend doing a Team Leader's job is an hour you didn't spend making them capable of doing it without you.

This is the section people skip and then relearn the hard way three months in, usually around the same time they realise they're busier than ever and nothing has actually improved.

DO NOT

- Micromanage every designer's file, revision, or sketch.
- Take over a Team Leader's responsibilities because it's faster than coaching them through it.
- Become the default answer to every small problem — that trains people to stop solving things themselves.
- Bypass Team Leaders unless the situation genuinely requires it.
- Create dependency on yourself, personally, for decisions your leaders should own.
- Take over client relationships that belong to the Client Relationship Manager or the relevant Team Leader.
- Publicly undermine a Team Leader, even when they're wrong.
- Jump to a solution before you understand the actual cause.
- Measure people only by hours logged or how busy they look.
- Chase only urgent fires while long-term development quietly never happens.

None of this means disappearing. It means being present in a way that builds capability instead of replacing it. The test for almost every decision in this role is simple:

THE TEST

Does this build a system or a leader that will still work when I'm not in the room — or does it just get today's problem out of my inbox?

05

PART ONE – THE ROLE

Authority & Reporting Structure

Everyone should be able to answer "who decides this?" without asking you.

- Founder** Business direction, strategic pricing and packages, major escalations, culture expectations, final call on hiring.
- Creative Head** Department-wide performance, Team Leader development, cross-team coordination, productivity, quality standards, problem-solving, capacity planning, process improvement.
- Team Leaders** Daily team management, task allocation, individual performance, quality checking within the team, team-level deadlines, coaching, escalating what's genuinely beyond them.
- Team Members** Executing assigned work, meeting quality and deadline standards, communicating blockers early, improving skills, following process.

Right now, Team Leaders at Brandstro split their time informally between managing their team and doing their own design work, with no fixed division. That ambiguity is exactly what this structure exists to reduce — not by banning Team Leaders from designing, but by making clear that when the two conflict, the team's performance is the job, and their own output is secondary.

WHERE RESPONSIBILITY STARTS AND ENDS

SITUATION	WHO OWNS IT FIRST
A designer's revision count is climbing on one project	Team Leader
The same revision pattern is happening across two teams	Creative Head
A client threatens to leave over a missed deadline	Founder, informed immediately by Creative Head
A Team Leader consistently misses their own team's deadlines	Creative Head coaches; escalates to Founder only if it doesn't improve

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PART ONE – THE ROLE

The Agency You're Leading

Brandstro is not a generic design studio. It's a branding agency — and one function inside it doesn't serve clients at all.

Everything in this handbook applies across Brandstro, but two environments inside the agency run on different logic, and treating them the same is a mistake worth naming early.

CLIENT-FACING PRODUCTION

- Logo / Brand Identity Team
- Packaging Team
- R&D / Sketch Team

Judged by: client approval, revision count, on-time delivery, technical quality.

INTERNAL AGENCY CONTENT

- Content Creation Team
- Agency social media, reels, portfolio, case studies, campaigns

Judged by: consistency of output, how well it sells Brandstro itself, not client sign-off.

The Content Team's job is to market **Brandstro** — not to serve an external client. Treat it as an internal business-growth function with its own calendar and its own creative direction, not as a fifth client-service team competing for the same kind of attention as Packaging.

THE TEAMS YOU'RE COORDINATING

TEAM	OWNS
Logo / Brand Identity	Logo concepts, identity systems, typography, colour systems, brand guidelines, applications.
Packaging	Packaging concepts, label design, structural thinking, print-readiness, mockups.
R&D / Sketch	Visual research, concept exploration, sketching, references — in support of Logo and Packaging.
Internal Content	Brandstro's own social presence, portfolio storytelling, case studies, campaigns.

CENTRAL MESSAGE OF THIS HANDBOOK

You are being promoted because you have already shown you can make other people better at doing the work — not because you're good at doing the work yourself. Turning the Logo Team around was the evidence. Building a system where Logo, Packaging, R&D and Content can each keep improving on their own is the job now.

Discussion Pages — End of Part One

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

TEN SECTIONS

Leading the Leaders

The core skill of the role: coaching, performance, conflict, delegation, feedback and culture — applied to Team Leaders first, and through them, to everyone else.

- 07 You Are Now a Leader of Leaders
- 08 Performance Management Framework
- 09 Handling Underperforming Employees
- 10 Problem-Solving Framework
- 11 Handling Team Conflict
- 12 Delegation
- 13 Micromanagement vs Leadership
- 14 Communication
- 15 How to Give Feedback
- 16 Team Culture

07

PART TWO — LEADING THE LEADERS

You Are Now a Leader of Leaders

The single highest-leverage use of your time is making each Team Leader better at their job.

Every hour spent coaching a Team Leader well multiplies across everyone on their team, every week, indefinitely. That is a better return than almost anything else you could do with the hour — including doing the design work yourself.

WHAT "COACHING A TEAM LEADER" ACTUALLY MEANS

- **Review, don't rescue.** Look at their team's numbers with them; let them propose the fix first.
- **Set expectations explicitly.** Don't assume a Team Leader knows what "good" looks like unless you've said it out loud.
- **Give feedback on their leadership, not just their team's output.** "Your team missed the deadline" is a team problem. "You didn't flag the risk three days earlier when you could see it coming" is a leadership problem — and it's the one to coach.
- **Challenge weak decisions before they become habits.** If a Team Leader keeps absorbing overflow work personally instead of reallocating it, that's a pattern to interrupt early.
- **Teach the skills underneath the job:** delegation, planning, difficult conversations, performance management.

THE WEEKLY TEAM LEADER REVIEW — WHAT TO ASK EVERY LEADER, EVERY WEEK

AREA	QUESTION TO ASK
Output	What did your team finish this week, and what's still open?
Quality	What needed rework, and why?
Deadlines	What's at risk in the next seven days?
Client blockers	What's waiting on a client response or approval?
Team discipline & morale	Anything you're worried about with a specific person?
Bottlenecks	Where did work sit idle, and why?
Resourcing	Do you have enough people for what's coming next week?
Improvement action	What's one thing you'll do differently next week?

HOLD ONTO THIS

You are not there to answer for their team. You are there so they get better at answering for it themselves.

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Performance Management Framework

You can't improve what you don't measure — but KPIs exist to improve people, not to intimidate them.

DIMENSION	THE REAL QUESTION
Output	How much work is actually being completed?
Quality	How good is the work, honestly?
Timeliness	Are deadlines being met?
Consistency	Is this stable, or dependent on one person's mood that week?
Efficiency	How much time and back-and-forth does it take to get there?
Improvement	Are people visibly getting better over time?
Accountability	Do people own their part, or explain it away?
Collaboration	Does this team make other teams' jobs easier or harder?
Problem-solving	Do people solve things themselves, or escalate everything?

PRACTICAL SCORECARD KPIS FOR A BRANDSTRO CREATIVE TEAM

Tasks assigned vs completed	On-time completion %	Revision rounds per project	Rework hours
Escalations	Client-facing errors		

These are the same signals already visible in how Brandstro runs today — R&D output, sketch turnaround, one logo per designer per day, revision rounds per client — just tracked deliberately instead of held in memory. Use a scorecard so a "bad month" is a fact you can point to, not a feeling either of you has to defend.

CAREFUL

KPIs used to catch people out train people to hide problems. KPIs used to spot where coaching is needed train people to raise their hand early. Same numbers, opposite culture, depending on how you use them.

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PART TWO — LEADING THE LEADERS

Handling Underperforming Employees

"This person is bad" is not a diagnosis. "This person's current performance is below the required standard, for this reason" is.

- 1 **Identify** — what exactly is underperforming? Name the specific output, not a general impression.
- 2 **Measure** — use the scorecard, not memory or a single bad week.
- 3 **Diagnose** — find the actual cause (see below).
- 4 **Coach** — a direct conversation, grounded in evidence, not accusation.
- 5 **Set an improvement plan** — specific, achievable, written down.
- 6 **Give a timeline** — a real date, not "soon."
- 7 **Review progress** — on the date you set, not whenever it comes up.
- 8 **Escalate if necessary** — to the Founder, with the full record, not just a complaint.

POSSIBLE CAUSES — DON'T GUESS, CHECK

- Skill gap
- Lack of clarity on the brief or standard
- Lack of training
- Wrong role for their strengths
- Workload — too much, or too little
- Poor management above them
- Personal issues outside work
- A process problem, not a people problem

A designer missing quality on packaging mockups might be undertrained on print-ready file setup, not careless. A Team Leader who keeps missing reviews might be buried doing design work they should have delegated. Diagnose before you coach — the coaching conversation is completely different depending on the cause.

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Problem-Solving Framework

Don't solve symptoms. Solve causes.

When a project runs late, the easy response is "work faster." The useful response is to find out why it was ever going to be late in the first place — because "work faster" fixes nothing the next time the same thing happens.

THE 5 WHYS, APPLIED TO A REAL BRANDSTRO PATTERN

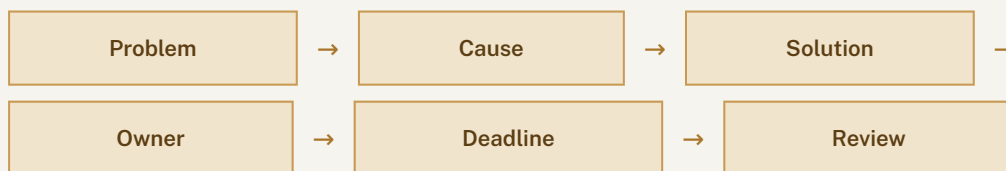
Why was the packaging project three days late? → The designer was waiting on R&D direction.

Why was R&D late? → R&D was covering two projects that day and this one wasn't flagged urgent.

Why wasn't it flagged? → There's no shared view of which projects are close to deadline.

Why isn't there one? → Nobody owns a simple, visible tracker across teams.

Root cause: a coordination gap, not a slow designer.



NINE QUESTIONS FOR ANY RECURRING OFFICE PROBLEM

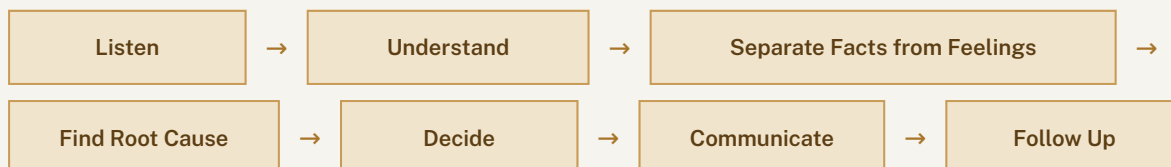
1. What happened, exactly?
2. Why did it happen?
3. Is this an individual problem or a system problem?
4. Has this happened before?
5. Who owns the problem?
6. What immediate action is required?
7. What prevents it from happening again?
8. How will we measure improvement?
9. When will we review it?

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Handling Team Conflict

Every kind of conflict in a creative team follows the same resolution path — only the parties change.



CONFLICT TYPES YOU'LL SEE

- Designer vs Designer
- Designer vs Team Leader
- Team Leader vs Team Leader
- Team Leader vs you
- Ego clashes over creative direction
- Blame culture after a missed deadline
- Unequal workload complaints
- Quality or deadline disagreements

SAMPLE CONVERSATION OPENER

"I want to understand both sides before anyone decides anything. [Person A], tell me what happened from where you sat. [Person B], same for you. I'm not looking for who's right yet — just what actually happened."

Two Team Leaders blaming each other for a missed handoff between R&D and Packaging is common enough to plan for. Resist picking a side in the room. Get both accounts, find the actual handoff gap, fix the process, and only then address any individual behaviour that needs correcting — separately, not in front of each other.

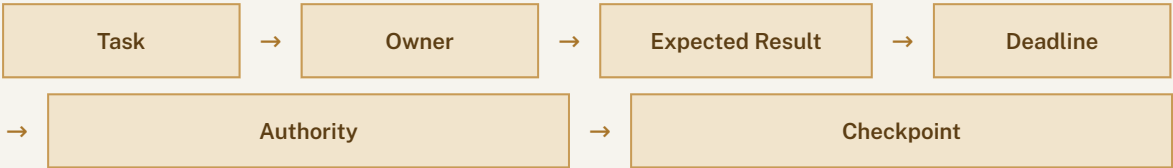
12

PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Delegation

If you do everything yourself, you have created a dependency, not a team.

This applies to you and it applies to every Team Leader below you. Right now, Team Leaders split time between managing their team and doing their own design work with no fixed line between the two. Left alone, that always drifts toward more designing and less managing — because designing has a visible, finishable output and managing often doesn't. Teach every Team Leader to notice that drift in themselves.



WHAT TO DELEGATE, AND HOW MUCH AUTHORITY TO GIVE

DELEGATE	KEEP
Day-to-day task allocation within a team	Department-wide priority calls
First-pass quality review	Coaching Team Leaders on how they review
Client-ready file checks	Cross-team resourcing decisions
Routine client updates on progress	Anything that changes scope, pricing or timeline

Monitoring without micromanaging means checking outcomes at the checkpoint you agreed — not walking past someone's screen every hour. If a Team Leader needs that kind of oversight to perform, that's a coaching conversation, not a reason to take the task back.

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Micromanagement vs Leadership

Leadership doesn't mean disappearing. It means creating visibility without creating suffocation.

MICROMANAGER

- Reviews every file before it moves an inch
- Reacts to mistakes with blame
- Makes every decision themselves
- Trusts no one by default
- Gives feedback only when something's wrong
- Delegates tasks, never authority
- Develops dependency on themselves
- Solves every problem personally

LEADER

- Reviews at agreed checkpoints
- Reacts to mistakes with a fix and a lesson
- Lets the right person decide at the right level
- Trusts by default, verifies with evidence
- Gives feedback as a habit, not a punishment
- Delegates the outcome, not just the task
- Builds a team that works without them
- Builds people who solve problems themselves

HOLD ONTO THIS

Being easy to talk to is not the same as being easy to walk over. Being firm is not the same as being arrogant. You can hold both.

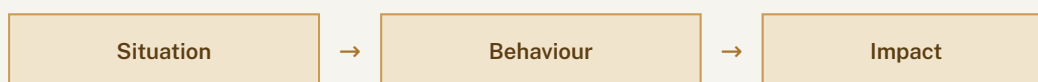
14

PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Communication

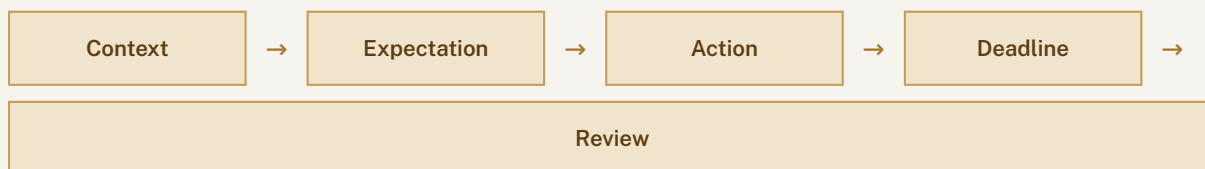
Two frameworks will carry almost every conversation you need to have in this role.

SBI – FOR FEEDBACK



"In yesterday's client review (situation), the mockup was sent without the die-line checked (behaviour), which meant the client caught a print error we should have caught first (impact)."

CLEAR – FOR INSTRUCTIONS AND DELEGATION



WHERE TONE CHANGES

AUDIENCE	WHAT CHANGES
Team Leaders	Peer-level directness; discuss trade-offs, not just instructions.
Junior designers	More context, more explanation of "why," patience with questions.
Founder	Lead with the headline and the recommendation, not the full story first.

Saying "no" is part of this job — to a Team Leader who wants to skip a review step, to a request that would bypass a process for convenience. Say it plainly, with the reason attached, and offer what you can say "yes" to instead.

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

How to Give Feedback

*Don't attack the person. Correct the behaviour.***ATTACKS THE PERSON**

- "You are careless."
- "You never think things through."
- "This is exactly like last time."

CORRECTS THE BEHAVIOUR

- "This task had three avoidable errors, which cost us extra revision time."
- "Let's look at what led to that, and how we prevent it next time."
- "What would help you catch this before it goes out?"

FIVE KINDS OF FEEDBACK YOU'LL GIVE IN THIS ROLE

TYPE	WHEN
Positive	Reinforce specifically — name what worked, not just "good job."
Corrective	Address a specific, recent, observable behaviour.
Performance	Tied to the scorecard, at a scheduled review.
Leadership	To a Team Leader, about how they led — not what their team produced.
Difficult	Serious, repeated, or values-based issues — planned, private, direct.

RULE OF THUMB*Praise publicly. Correct privately.*

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Team Culture

Friendly workplace does not mean casual accountability.

Brandstro is three months old. It doesn't have three years of accumulated habits yet — which means the culture forming right now is unusually easy to shape, and unusually easy to shape badly by accident. What you reward and what you let slide in these next few months becomes "how we do things here" for a long time.

BUILD TOWARD

- Accountability and ownership
- Respect across teams
- Discipline without fear
- Learning and honest mistakes
- Quality as a habit, not an inspection
- Transparency about problems
- Professionalism under deadline pressure
- Continuous, unglamorous improvement

REWARD

Raising a problem early. Admitting a mistake before it's found. Helping another team hit its deadline. Asking a clarifying question instead of guessing.

DON'T TOLERATE

Hiding a slipping deadline until it's a crisis. Blaming another team without checking facts. Repeating the same avoidable error without adjusting.

Psychological safety and low accountability are not the same thing. A team where people feel safe naming a problem — and are still expected to fix it — is the target. A team where nothing is anyone's fault is not psychological safety; it's an absence of standards.

Discussion Pages — End of Part Two

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

SIX SECTIONS

Running the Department

Workload, coordination, client boundaries, quality, training and the pipeline of future leaders — the operational half of the job.

-
- 17 Productivity & Workload Management
 - 18 Cross-Team Coordination
 - 19 Client Involvement
 - 20 Quality Control
 - 21 Training & Development
 - 22 Leadership Pipeline

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Productivity & Workload Management

You cannot manage capacity you haven't measured.

Brandstro's throughput is already fairly well understood at the individual level: R&D can direct roughly two projects a day, the Sketch Artist about one sketch a day, a Logo designer about one logo a day, and standalone label or packaging work runs one to two days plus a few more for confirmation rounds. That's real capacity data — the gap is turning it into a plan before the month gets busy, not after.

This month is the clearest example available: thirty new clients came in, but only six to eight projects have been completed, with the team fully loaded and no prior structure to manage the surge. That's not a motivation problem. It's a capacity-planning problem, and it will keep repeating until it's treated as one.

TOOLS TO INTRODUCE

TOOL	WHAT IT ANSWERS
Capacity Planning	Given today's team, how many projects can realistically start this week?
Workload Dashboard	Who is overloaded, who has room, right now?
Priority Matrix	Urgent-and-important vs important-but-not-urgent — what actually goes first?
Daily Task Review	Is today's plan still realistic by lunchtime?
Weekly Capacity Review	Are we about to overcommit next week?

HOLD ONTO THIS

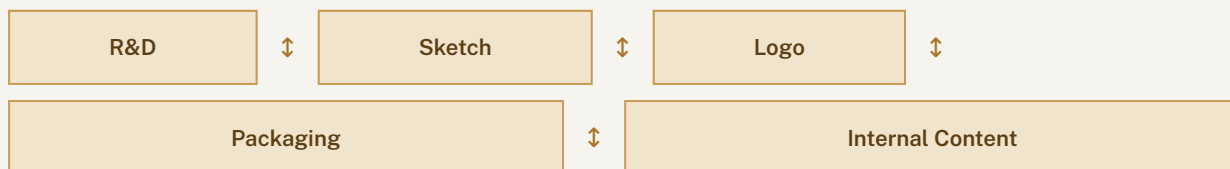
Thirty clients onboarded against six to eight completed isn't a sign the team needs to work harder. It's a sign intake needs to be paced to what the team can actually absorb.

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Cross-Team Coordination

Most delays don't happen inside a team. They happen in the handoff between teams.



Today, R&D sometimes briefs the Sketch Artist, sometimes sends ideas straight to Logo, and sometimes a Logo team member originates the concept themselves. All three paths can work — but only if everyone knows, for a given project, which path is happening. Ambiguity about the handoff is where "I thought R&D was still working on it" delays come from.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR AT EVERY HANDOFF

- Is it clear who has the project right now, at all times?
- Are shared resources (a sketch, a reference, a brief) available to the next team without asking around?
- Is there a visible signal when something is close to deadline, so it doesn't compete evenly with everything else?
- Is work ever being duplicated because two people didn't know someone else already started it?

SIMPLE FIX WORTH TESTING

A single shared status view — even a basic sheet — showing project, current owner, and days-to-deadline. Most cross-team delays disappear once "who has this right now" stops being a question anyone has to ask out loud.

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Client Involvement

You are not the Client Relationship Manager. Don't quietly become one.

You may attend important client meetings, join creative discussions, support a difficult project, or represent creative leadership when it genuinely calls for it. What you should avoid is absorbing day-to-day client communication that belongs to the CRM or the relevant Team Leader — every time you take that on personally, you make the department more dependent on you, not less.

SITUATION	YOUR ROLE
Routine revision request	Team Leader handles it directly
Client unhappy after multiple revision rounds	You join to understand the creative disagreement, alongside the CRM
Major client escalation or threat to leave	You and the Founder together
Understanding what clients actually want, in general	You track patterns across projects to inform brief quality and training

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Quality Control

Quality should be built into the process, not inspected only at the end.

Catching a weak logo concept at final client presentation is expensive — in time, in the client's confidence, and in the revision rounds that follow. Catching the same weakness at the R&D or sketch stage costs almost nothing. The earlier the checkpoint, the cheaper the fix.

STANDARDS WORTH WRITING DOWN ONCE, FOR EVERY TEAM

- Design standards and brand consistency
- Technical accuracy (print-ready, die-lines, colour modes)
- File organisation and naming conventions
- Presentation standards for client decks
- Revision control — which version is current
- Who gives final approval before a client sees it

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Training & Development

Ask, for every person: what's the one skill that would move them forward fastest?

- 1 Current skill — where are they today, honestly?
- 2 Required skill — what does the next level of their role actually need?
- 3 Gap — name the specific distance between the two.
- 4 Training — how will they close it?
- 5 Practice — where do they apply it on real work?
- 6 Review — did it actually close?

Ask this continuously: who needs training, what skills are missing on each team, who's ready for more responsibility, who could mentor someone junior. This doesn't need a formal HR process to start — it needs you noticing and writing it down.

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Leadership Pipeline

Brandstro should never depend on one or two leaders forever — including you.



Look for the signals continuously, not once a year: who solves problems without being asked, who other people naturally go to for help, who stays reliable under deadline pressure, who's already informally mentoring a junior teammate. Your own path — Logo designer to Logo Team Leader to Overall Creative Head — is the proof this pipeline works. It should not be the only example of it three years from now.

Discussion Pages — End of Part Three

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

EIGHT SECTIONS

Leadership Inside a Branding Agency

This is not generic creative leadership. This is how leadership works specifically inside a business that sells brand strategy, identity and packaging — where the vocabulary is concepts, revisions and client presentations.

-
- 23 Evaluating Creative Quality
 - 24 Creative Process Management
 - 25 Revision Management
 - 26 Creative vs Commercial Thinking
 - 27 Brief Quality
 - 28 Creative Review System
 - 29 Managing the Internal Content Team
 - 30 Branding-Agency Performance Dashboard

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Evaluating Creative Quality

"Looks good" is not an evaluation. It's the absence of one.

Every review you give a Team Leader or a designer should be able to answer three questions: why is it good, what problem does it solve, and what could be stronger. That habit, repeated in every review, is what actually trains a team's creative judgement — far more than any single correction does.

DIMENSION	WHAT TO ACTUALLY ASK
Concept strength	Is there a real idea here, or just decoration?
Strategic relevance	Does it fit the brand's actual positioning, or just look nice in isolation?
Distinctiveness	Would this stand out next to five competitors' logos?
Simplicity & memorability	Could someone describe it after seeing it once?
Scalability	Does it hold up as a favicon and as a shopfront sign?
Typography & colour	Are these choices deliberate, or default?
Application	Does it work across packaging, stationery, a t-shirt?
Technical execution	Is the file actually production-ready?

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PART FOUR — LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Creative Process Management

Know the workflow well enough to spot exactly where a project is stuck.

- 1 Brief — client pays 50%, discovery call gathers direction.
- 2 R&D — concept research and direction (~2 projects/day capacity).
- 3 Sketch — minimal notebook sketch from the Sketch Artist (~1/day), sometimes skipped.
- 4 Design Development — Logo or Packaging team builds the concept out (~1 logo/day).
- 5 Team Leader Review — internal quality pass before it goes further.
- 6 Client Presentation — mockup delivered (typically ~5-page for logo).
- 7 Feedback & Revision — looped back into design, no formal sign-off step exists yet.
- 8 Final Delivery — remaining 50% collected before files are handed over.

The one gap worth naming directly: there's currently no formal client sign-off step between presentation and "done." That's exactly the kind of ambiguity that turns one more small tweak into an unplanned fourth revision round. Closing that gap is a process fix, not a talent fix.

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Revision Management

The goal is not "reduce revisions." The goal is stronger thinking before the work ever reaches the client.

Brandstro's current pattern is actually informative: some clients approve the first draft outright, some ("fine" clients) need around two corrections, a few need three or more rounds, and very few need five or more. That spread is a real signal — first-presentation quality is already strong for a meaningful share of projects, and weak somewhere specific for the rest. The job is finding out where, not assuming revisions are evenly distributed bad luck.

FOUR THINGS TO TRACK

METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Revision Rate	How many rounds, on average, per project type
First-Presentation Quality	What share of projects are approved on the first draft
Revision Root Cause	Was it a genuine design miss, or subjective client preference?
Client Feedback Pattern	Do the same kinds of notes keep recurring across different clients?

DISTINGUISH THESE TWO, EVERY TIME

Genuine design problem: the brief's objective wasn't actually met. Fix the thinking. **Subjective preference:** the work is solid but not to this client's personal taste. Fix the brief-gathering, not the design team.

Since the ₹15,000 branding package currently sells with informally unlimited revisions for a few clients, this isn't only a quality question — it's a margin question. A project stuck at five rounds is eating designer time that was priced for two. Revision discipline protects the team's time as much as it protects quality.

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Creative vs Commercial Thinking

A beautiful design that doesn't solve the client's problem hasn't succeeded.

Neither has a safe design with no creative distinction.

Teach every Team Leader to hold both questions at once, on every project: is this creatively strong, and does it actually do the commercial job the client hired us for? A logo that wins internal admiration but confuses the target customer has failed just as surely as one that's technically safe but forgettable.

ASK BOTH

"Would I be proud to put this in the portfolio?" *and* "Would this actually help this specific client's business?" If the answer to either is no, it isn't finished yet.

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Brief Quality

Garbage brief → confused thinking → weak creative output → excessive revisions.

Weak output often doesn't start with the designer. It starts three steps earlier, at the discovery call, when a question that mattered didn't get asked.

THE BRIEFING CHECKLIST

- What is the brand, in one sentence?
- Who is the target audience?
- What is the positioning?
- What is the business objective?
- What should the brand communicate — and avoid?
- Who are the competitors?
- What are the exact deliverables and deadline?
- What does the client expect to see first?
- Any reference direction or strategic constraint?

Use **[CLIENT INPUT REQUIRED]** style flags anywhere a brief is missing something instead of letting R&D quietly assume an answer — an assumed answer that turns out wrong is exactly what produces a revision round that didn't need to happen.

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Creative Review System

Before work moves forward, someone should deliberately check seven things — not just glance and approve.

CHECK	QUESTION
Strategy	Does the concept actually make sense for this brand?
Concept	Is there a strong idea underneath the execution?
Design	Is the execution itself strong?
Brand Fit	Does it genuinely belong to this brand, or could it belong to anyone?
Distinctiveness	Does it stand apart from competitors?
Application	Will it hold up in real-world use — packaging, signage, small sizes?
Technical Quality	Is the file actually production-ready?

This is the checkpoint that should sit before client presentation, every time — not as an extra delay, but as the reason the client sees fewer weak first drafts.

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Managing the Internal Content Creation Team

This team sells Brandstro. It doesn't serve a client — treat it that way.

The Content Team owns Brandstro's own Instagram behind-the-scenes presence, portfolio storytelling, case studies, and campaigns — including projects like the agency's own reels account and lead-generation experiments. Its output markets the agency itself, so judge it by a different yardstick than client-facing production: consistency and how well it builds the Brandstro brand, not client sign-off.

YOU OWN DIRECTION AND QUALITY. THE CONTENT TEAM LEADER OWNS DAILY EXECUTION.

YOU ENSURE

- A content calendar exists and is followed
- Creative direction stays consistent with the agency's brand
- Case studies actually get made from finished client work
- Quality control before anything publishes

THEY OWN

- Shoot planning and editing workflow
- Day-to-day posting and scheduling
- The approval process before publish

Don't become this team's daily task manager unless something is genuinely broken. The same leverage principle from Part One applies here as much as it does to Logo or Packaging.

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PART FOUR — LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Branding-Agency Performance Dashboard

A dashboard built for what Brandstro actually sells — not a generic agency template.

AREA	TRACK
Production	Projects received, completed, in progress, pending, delayed
Logo / Identity	Concepts completed, first-presentation quality, revision rounds, turnaround time
Packaging	Concepts completed, revision rounds, turnaround time, technical errors caught
R&D	Concepts/research delivered, support requests, turnaround time
Internal Content	Content planned vs produced vs published, pending items
People	Attendance, productivity, training progress, leadership development

This doesn't need new software to start. It needs the numbers Brandstro already generates — logo-only at ₹6,000, the ₹15,000 branding package, the current team of one R&D, one Sketch Artist, a four-person Logo team, and a Packaging team of a ₹12,000 Team Leader, a ₹12,000 senior member and two ₹10,000 members — tracked on a simple weekly sheet instead of held in memory.

HOLD ONTO THIS

You don't need a perfect dashboard on day one. You need one number per team, tracked every week, that you actually look at.

Discussion Pages — End of Part Four

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

ELEVEN SECTIONS

Operating Discipline

The daily habits, decisions and character that make everything in Parts Two through Four actually happen, week after week.

-
- 31 Daily / Weekly / Monthly Responsibilities
 - 32 Meeting Structures
 - 33 Decision-Making
 - 34 Escalation Management
 - 35 Accountability
 - 36 Emotional Intelligence
 - 37 Leadership Character
 - 38 Trust & Authority
 - 39 Handling Mistakes
 - 40 Building Systems
 - 41 Continuous Improvement & Growth Mindset

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Daily / Weekly / Monthly Responsibilities

A role this broad only stays manageable with a fixed rhythm.

DAILY

- Check overall workload and critical deadlines across all four teams
- Check for bottlenecks and yesterday's carry-overs
- Confirm Team Leader priorities for the day
- Handle anything genuinely urgent; resist handling everything else

WEEKLY

- Run the structured Team Leader Review (Section 07)
- Review pending work, quality trends, and training progress
- Set next week's priorities across teams

MONTHLY

- Department-level performance review — team-wise and overall
- Review quality and productivity trends, not just the latest snapshot
- Review the Leader's Scorecard with the Founder (Section 45)
- Set next month's priorities and flag resourcing needs early

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Meeting Structures

Every recurring meeting should earn its place on the calendar.

MEETING	LENGTH	PURPOSE
Daily leadership check-in	10–15 min	Surface today's risks before they grow
Weekly Team Leader Meeting	30–45 min	The structured review from Section 07
Monthly Department Review	60 min	Trends, scorecard, next month's priorities
One-to-One Employee Review	15–20 min	Individual development, not just output
Performance Improvement Meeting	As needed	Section 09's framework, in person
Problem-Solving Meeting	As needed	Section 10's framework, with the right people in the room
Post-Project Review	15 min	What worked, what didn't, on a completed project

For each: know the purpose, who needs to be there, the questions you'll ask, and what action items leave the room with an owner and a date. A meeting without an action item was a conversation, not a decision.

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Decision-Making

Decide → Delegate → Monitor → Review.

DECIDE INDEPENDENTLY WHEN	CONSULT TEAM LEADERS WHEN	CONSULT OR ESCALATE TO FOUNDER WHEN
It's within a single team's normal operation	It affects how a team works day-to-day	It changes pricing, scope, or a client relationship
It's reversible if wrong	The Team Leader has context you don't	It's a hiring, firing, or major spend decision
It's within your established authority	It sets a precedent across teams	It's a serious, repeated people problem

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Escalation Management

Don't escalate every small problem upward. Never hide a serious one to make performance look good.

LEVEL	WHO HANDLES IT	EXAMPLE
Level 1 — Team-level	Team Leader	A designer needs a second revision pass
Level 2 — Cross-team or repeated	Creative Head	The same handoff keeps breaking between R&D and Packaging
Level 3 — Major business, people, or client issue	Founder / Management	A client threatens to leave; a serious conduct issue

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Accountability

Responsibility without accountability creates excuses.

WHAT?	WHO?	WHEN?	EXPECTED STANDARD?	CURRENT STATUS?	NEXT ACTION?

Learn to hear the difference between an explanation, an excuse, and a root cause. "I was waiting on R&D" can be any of the three depending on whether it's followed by "...and I should have flagged it two days earlier" or by nothing at all.

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Emotional Intelligence

A leader cannot react emotionally to every problem — the team learns your reactions faster than your words.

DON'T

- Shout or raise your voice
- Insult or embarrass someone publicly
- Decide anything while angry
- Play favourites, or punish based on assumptions

Be calm, firm and fair — especially when a mistake is genuinely costly. The calmer your response to a real problem, the more people will bring you real problems early.

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Leadership Character

The standard you set becomes the standard they follow.

People copy behaviour far more than they follow instructions. If you're punctual, disciplined, and honest about your own mistakes, that becomes normal on every team you touch — without you ever writing a rule about it.

- Punctuality
- Discipline
- Professional communication
- Ownership
- Work ethic
- Honesty, even when inconvenient
- Confidentiality
- Consistency — the same standard on a good day and a bad one

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Trust & Authority

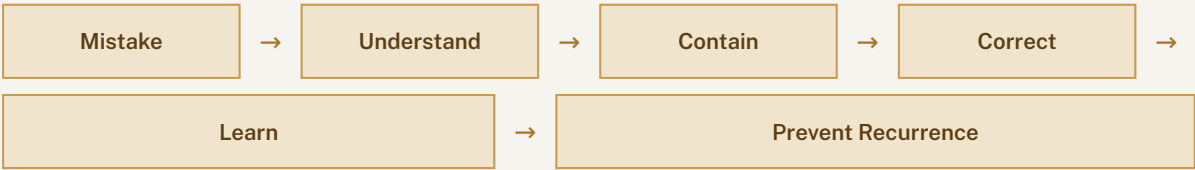
Hold both sides of each pair below – not one at the expense of the other.

BE	BUT NOT
Approachable	Easy to manipulate
Friendly	Favouritism-driven
Understanding	Weak on standards
Firm	Arrogant

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Handling Mistakes



Not every mistake deserves the same response. Know the difference before you react.

TYPE	RIGHT RESPONSE
Honest mistake	Fix it, no drama, note it for pattern-spotting
Repeated negligence	A direct, documented conversation
Lack of skill	Training, not discipline
Lack of attention	Understand the cause — workload, distraction, unclear priority
Intentional misconduct	Escalate to the Founder

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Building Systems

A recurring problem needs a system. It doesn't need another reminder to "work faster."

If deadlines are repeatedly missed, don't start with "try harder." Investigate: was it planning, capacity, unclear task allocation, a vague brief, a slow approval, a skill gap, or a review bottleneck? Then build the system that removes that specific cause — a checklist, a dashboard, an approval step, a training module, an escalation rule.

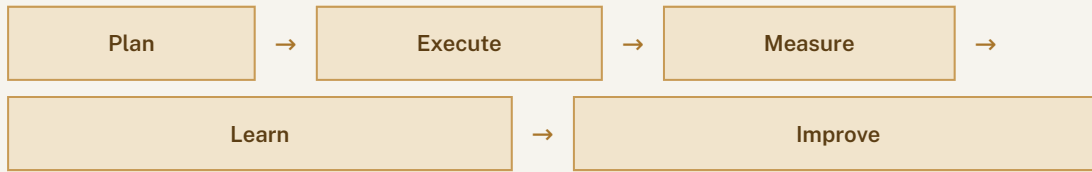
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Part Five – Operating Discipline

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Continuous Improvement & Growth Mindset



Ask every month: what worked, what failed, what repeated, what wasted time, what created unnecessary revisions, what could be simplified, what should stop, start, or continue?

THE GROWTH-MINDSET QUESTION

If the team doubled in size tomorrow, would today's system survive? If not, that's the thing to fix now — while it's still cheap to fix.

Discussion Pages — End of Part Five

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

ONE SECTION

The First 90 Days

A practical runway for the transition — understand, then improve, then scale.

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PART SIX – THE FIRST 90 DAYS

The 30 / 60 / 90-Day Plan

Don't try to fix everything in week one. Understand first, improve second, scale third.

DAYS 1-30 – UNDERSTAND

- Understand all four teams and how work actually flows between them today
- Sit with each Team Leader; understand their real strengths and real gaps
- Map current problems — starting with Packaging, but across every team
- Establish baseline KPIs so "improvement" can be measured, not just felt

DAYS 31-60 – IMPROVE

- Fix the highest-priority problems identified in month one
- Begin structured coaching with each Team Leader
- Introduce basic reporting — the weekly review, the shared status view
- Start closing the biggest recurring gaps (see: the missing client sign-off step, Section 24)

DAYS 61-90 – SCALE

- Standardise what worked in month two across all teams
- Build the first version of the leadership pipeline (Section 22)
- Establish a sustainable operating rhythm — the daily/weekly/monthly cadence in Section 31
- Report back to the Founder on what changed, with numbers

HOLD ONTO THIS

Ninety days from now, the honest question isn't "did I personally fix Packaging?" It's "can Packaging now fix itself, faster than it could ninety days ago?"

THREE SECTIONS

Practice

Sixteen situations you will actually run into at Brandstro, plus the questions worth asking yourself on repeat.

43 Real Office Scenarios

44 Leadership Self-Reflection Questions

45 The Leader's Monthly Scorecard

43

PART SEVEN — PRACTICE

Real Office Scenarios

Sixteen situations, built from how Brandstro actually runs. Talk through each one with the Founder before it happens for real.

01 The Packaging Team misses another deadline

WEAK MOVE	Take over the project personally to "just get it done."
STRONG MOVE	Sit with the Packaging Team Leader, run the 5 Whys, find whether it's capacity, handoff, or skill — then fix that, not this one project.
ASK	Is this the first time, or the fifth?
OUTCOME	The Team Leader leaves the conversation with a plan, not a rescue.

02 A designer argues with their Team Leader in front of others

WEAK MOVE	Publicly side with one of them on the spot.
STRONG MOVE	Separate them, hear both privately, resolve the actual issue, coach the Team Leader on de-escalating next time.
ASK	What was actually being disagreed about — creative direction, or something else entirely?
OUTCOME	The disagreement gets resolved without anyone losing face publicly.

03 A Team Leader is technically excellent but poor at managing people

WEAK MOVE	Let it slide because their own design output is strong.
STRONG MOVE	Name it directly — leadership and craft are different skills — and coach the specific behaviour (e.g. never delegating, avoiding hard conversations).
ASK	Is their team's performance actually good, or just their own personal output?
OUTCOME	They start being evaluated as a leader, not just a designer.

04 One designer consistently outperforms the rest of the team

WEAK MOVE	Quietly route all the hardest work to them, burning them out.
STRONG MOVE	Recognise them, and ask what's different about their approach that others could learn.
ASK	Are they a future Team Leader, or a specialist who's happiest designing?
OUTCOME	Their strength lifts the team instead of just carrying it.

05 A talented designer has poor discipline — late, inconsistent, misses small details

WEAK MOVE	Excuse it because the work is good when it does show up.
STRONG MOVE	Hold the same standard as everyone else — talent doesn't buy an exemption.
ASK	Would I accept this from someone whose work was average?
OUTCOME	The team sees standards apply equally, which protects morale.

06 A designer keeps escalating small problems to you directly

WEAK MOVE	Solve it for them every time — it's faster.
STRONG MOVE	Redirect them to their Team Leader, and tell the Team Leader this is happening.
ASK	Is this a training gap, a confidence gap, or a sign the Team Leader is unapproachable?
OUTCOME	The right level starts handling the right problems again.

07 A client's revision requests suddenly spike mid-project

WEAK MOVE	Absorb it silently and let the designer's workload quietly balloon.
STRONG MOVE	Check whether this is a genuine miss on the brief or scope creep, and involve the CRM if it's the latter.
ASK	Was this covered in the original brief, or is it new ground?
OUTCOME	The team's time is protected, and the client relationship stays clear.

08 Thirty new clients land in a month the team can only fully serve six to eight of

WEAK MOVE	Tell everyone to just work faster and hope it evens out.
STRONG MOVE	Build a capacity plan, communicate realistic timelines to new clients, and flag the sales/delivery mismatch to the Founder with numbers.
ASK	Is this a one-off surge, or the new normal we need to resource for?
OUTCOME	Expectations are set honestly instead of quietly missed.

09 A team is sitting idle while another is buried

WEAK MOVE	Not notice until someone complains.
STRONG MOVE	Use the shared status view to redistribute work or cross-train where possible.
ASK	Is this a one-week blip, or a sign of an underlying allocation problem?
OUTCOME	Capacity gets used where it's actually needed.

10 A Team Leader hides a performance issue on their team

WEAK MOVE	Only address it once it becomes a client-facing problem.
STRONG MOVE	Address it directly and privately — this is about trust, not just the underlying issue.
ASK	Did they hide it out of fear, or because they didn't think it mattered?
OUTCOME	The Team Leader understands hiding problems costs more trust than surfacing them.

11 An employee complains about unfair workload distribution

WEAK MOVE	Dismiss it without checking the actual numbers.
STRONG MOVE	Check the workload dashboard before responding — the complaint might be right.
ASK	Is the imbalance real, or does it just feel that way from where they sit?
OUTCOME	The response is grounded in fact, not just reassurance.

12 A high performer starts acting arrogant toward teammates

WEAK MOVE	Ignore it because their output is too valuable to risk upsetting them.
STRONG MOVE	Address the behaviour directly — high output doesn't exempt anyone from team culture.
ASK	Is this affecting the rest of the team's morale or output?
OUTCOME	Standards hold regardless of who's involved.

13 A junior designer shows early leadership potential

WEAK MOVE	Wait until a Team Leader role is vacant to notice them.
STRONG MOVE	Start giving them small ownership now — a mini-project lead, mentoring someone newer.
ASK	What's the smallest piece of real responsibility I could hand them this month?
OUTCOME	The leadership pipeline (Section 22) actually fills.

14 The same design mistake keeps happening on packaging files

WEAK MOVE	Correct it each time it appears and move on.
STRONG MOVE	Treat it as a system gap — add it to the pre-presentation checklist (Section 28) so it's caught structurally.
ASK	Has this happened at least three times? If so, it's a system problem now, not an individual one.
OUTCOME	The mistake stops recurring across the whole team, not just for one person.

15 A deadline is tomorrow and the work is visibly incomplete

WEAK MOVE	Panic, jump in and do it yourself overnight.
STRONG MOVE	Assess honestly with the Team Leader what's achievable, communicate to the client early if it's genuinely at risk, and only then decide who does what.
ASK	Could this have been flagged three days ago instead of tonight?
OUTCOME	A managed, honest outcome instead of a scramble — and a lesson for next time.

16 The Founder receives a direct complaint about creative quality

WEAK MOVE	Get defensive or downplay it to protect the team's reputation.
STRONG MOVE	Investigate honestly, bring the Founder the cause and a fix — not just an explanation.
ASK	Is this an isolated miss, or does it match a pattern I should already know about?
OUTCOME	The Founder trusts you more after the conversation, not less.

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PART SEVEN — PRACTICE

Leadership Self-Reflection Questions

Ask yourself these on repeat. Nobody else will ask them for you.

DAILY

- Did I improve the team today, or just react to it?
- Did I help a Team Leader get better at solving their own problem?
- Did I create dependency on myself anywhere today?
- Did I communicate clearly, or did I assume it landed?

WEEKLY

- Which team improved this week — and which one declined?
- Which Team Leader needs support I haven't offered yet?
- What problem repeated from last week?
- Who deserves recognition I haven't given?
- What system needs improving before it breaks again?

MONTHLY

- Is the department stronger than it was last month — measurably, not just by feel?
- Are my Team Leaders becoming more independent, or more reliant on me?
- Is quality improving? Is productivity?
- Are problems reducing, or just changing shape?
- Is the team ready for the next stage of growth?

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PART SEVEN — PRACTICE

The Leader's Monthly Scorecard

Thirteen categories. Rate honestly, 1 to 5, with the Founder — this is a conversation, not a report card.

#	CATEGORY	1	2	3	4	5
1	Overall Team Performance					
2	Team Leader Development					
3	Productivity					
4	Quality					
5	Deadline Management					
6	Problem Solving					
7	Employee Development					
8	Communication					
9	Discipline & Culture					
10	Process Improvement					
11	Cross-Team Coordination					
12	Leadership Pipeline					
13	Strategic Thinking					

1 = needs urgent attention · 3 = meeting the bar · 5 = a model other leaders should learn from

Discussion Pages — End of Part Seven

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

FOUR SECTIONS

Partnership & Close

How you and the Founder work together, what success actually looks like, the principles to carry forward, and a commitment to sign.

46 Founder ↔ Creative Head Working Relationship

47 What Success Looks Like

48 Final Leadership Principles

49 My Leadership Commitment

46

PART EIGHT – PARTNERSHIP & CLOSE

Founder ↔ Creative Head Working Relationship

Don't bring only problems to the Founder. Bring problems already halfway solved.

FOUNDER PROVIDES

- Direction and strategic priorities
- Feedback on your leadership
- Resources and major decisions
- Major escalation support

CREATIVE HEAD PROVIDES

- Honest department status
- Problems, with analysis attached
- Performance insights and trends
- Recommendations and escalations

THE FORMAT THAT EARNS TRUST

Problem + Analysis + Options + Recommendation. Not just "Packaging is behind again."

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PART EIGHT – PARTNERSHIP & CLOSE

What Success Looks Like

The answer is not "you personally do excellent design work."

- Team Leaders become stronger, more independent decision-makers
- Teams become less dependent on you being in the room
- Performance, quality and deadlines all trend upward
- Repeated problems decrease, month over month
- Employees are visibly developing, with a named next skill each
- The Founder needs to intervene less in day-to-day creative operations
- Brandstro can handle greater workload without breaking
- Future leaders are already emerging from inside the teams

HOLD ONTO THIS

The best evidence of your leadership is the performance of the people you lead — not the quality of what you personally produce.

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PART EIGHT – PARTNERSHIP & CLOSE

Final Leadership Principles

Twenty principles worth returning to whenever a situation feels unfamiliar.

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1. Lead people, not tasks. | 1. Don't create dependency on yourself. |
| 2. Build leaders, not followers. | 2. Standards must be consistent for everyone. |
| 3. Fix systems, not just symptoms. | 3. Don't play favourites. |
| 4. Measure before judging. | 4. Every recurring problem needs a system. |
| 5. Coach before criticising. | 5. Every leader needs feedback, including you. |
| 6. Delegate before doing it yourself. | 6. Every employee needs a visible path to improve. |
| 7. Be firm without being disrespectful. | 7. Protect quality. |
| 8. Be approachable without becoming weak. | 8. Protect culture. |
| 9. Praise publicly; correct privately. | 9. Think beyond today's deadline. |
| 10. Never hide a problem. | 10. Leave the team stronger than you found it. |

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PART EIGHT – PARTNERSHIP & CLOSE

My Leadership Commitment

Read this aloud together at the end of the session.

MY COMMITMENT

I take ownership of the performance of every team I lead — Logo, Packaging, R&D and Content — not by doing their work, but by developing the people who do.

I will support my Team Leaders before I bypass them, coach before I criticise, and build systems before I accept the same problem twice.

I will maintain the standards this agency is built on, treat every person fairly, and bring problems to the Founder honestly — with analysis and a recommendation, not just a complaint.

I will build an environment where great creative work happens whether or not I am personally in the room. That is how I will measure whether I am succeeding.

Creative Head Name: _____ Signature: _____

Date: _____

Founder Name: _____ Signature: _____

Date: _____

Brandstro

Performance Incentive Plan

Each person's own monthly project target, and exactly what it pays — base salary protected throughout

Prepared for: Zameel, Founder — Brandstro

Scope: All 12 team members — R&D, Sketch Artist, Logo Team, Packaging Team, CRM, HR

Company margin protected at: 40-50%, even when everyone hits their full target

How This Plan Works

Every person has their **own monthly project target** — not a shared company number. Base salary never changes and is never reduced. On top of it:

1. Your Baseline (no bonus)

A starting number of projects each month that's simply part of the job — covers your share of the company's running cost. No bonus here, but nothing lost either.

2. Bonus — for every project beyond your baseline

Real money per project, paid at a higher rate for clean work (0-1 client revisions) and a lower rate for heavy revisions. This is **yours** — earned by your own work, not tied to what anyone else does.

In one line: hit your own monthly number, with clean quality, and you reach your target earning — on your own effort, every month, regardless of how the rest of the team is doing.

Team Leaders work slightly differently (see their pages): 70% of their bonus comes from their team hitting its target, 30% from their own personal design work — because their real job is getting their team there, not just designing.

Monthly Sales Target — Zameel's Number to Hit

This is the total client volume that makes every individual target on the following pages achievable — this is what Zameel needs to keep selling every month.

Product	Price	Monthly Target	Revenue
Logo Design Only	₹6,000	8	₹48,000
Branding + Logo Package	₹15,000	16	₹2,40,000
Standalone Label Design	₹2,500 (1st)	15	₹37,500
Standalone Packaging Design	₹3,500 (1st)	8	₹28,000
Total — 47 client engagements / month	—	—	₹3,53,500

Why this mix works better: Logo-only and Branding both use the same scarce resource — the Sketch Artist, who can only produce 24 sketches a month either way. So the smart move is to sell more of the higher-value Branding package (₹15,000) and less plain Logo-only (₹6,000) within that same fixed 24 — revenue goes up without asking the Sketch Artist or Logo team to do anything extra. Pulling standalone Label and Packaging design back to 15 and 8/month also gives the Packaging team real breathing room again.

What eased up: the Packaging team now uses about 58 of its 84 available working days/month — a comfortable buffer, versus almost zero room before. The one thing worth watching in month one: Branding packages (16, up from 10) carry more deliverables per project than Logo-only, so keep an eye on whether that team's pace holds steady.

R&D

1 person — concept research & creative direction

Base salary

₹10,000

Target monthly earning

₹12,000

Researches every logo and branding concept before it reaches the Sketch Artist or Logo Team.

Your Monthly Target

Baseline (no bonus)	Your Target	Beyond baseline
18 concepts/month	24 concepts/month	6 concepts

Bonus — per concept beyond baseline

Downstream outcome	Bonus per concept
Reaches final design with 0-1 revisions	₹350
Reaches final design with 2-3 revisions	₹175
4+ revisions	₹0

How you reach ₹12,000

Concepts delivered	24 (18 baseline + 6 beyond)
Of the 6 extra: clean / partial	5 clean, 1 with 2-3 revisions
Bonus	$(5 \times ₹350) + (1 \times ₹175) = ₹1,925$
Total earnings	₹10,000 + ₹1,925 ≈ ₹12,000

Sketch Artist

1 person — hand sketches from R&D concepts

Base salary
₹10,000

Target monthly earning

₹15,000

The one role the whole company's output is capped by — one sketch a day. You're already at full capacity, so your bonus is earned through quality, not extra volume.

Your Monthly Target

Sketches/month	What decides your bonus
24 (your full monthly capacity)	% of your sketches the Logo Team completes with no rework

Bonus — Quality Tier

% of sketches needing no rework	Monthly Bonus
90% or higher	₹5,000
75% – 89%	₹3,000
60% – 74%	₹1,500
Below 60%	₹0

How you reach ₹15,000

Sketches delivered	24
Clean pass-through rate	91% (22 of 24 needed no rework)
Bonus tier	90%+ → ₹5,000
Total earnings	₹10,000 + ₹5,000 = ₹15,000

Logo Designer

3 people — develops sketches into final logo files

Base salary
₹10,000

Target monthly earning

₹15,000

Turns R&D + Sketch Artist concepts into finished, client-ready logo files and mockups.

Your Monthly Target

Baseline (no bonus)	Your Target	Beyond baseline
4 logos/month	7 logos/month	3 logos

Bonus — per logo beyond baseline

Revisions requested by client	Bonus per logo
0-1 revisions	₹1,650
2-3 revisions	₹825
4+ revisions (unless flagged as client scope change)	₹0

How you reach ₹15,000

Logos completed	7 (4 baseline + 3 beyond)
Of the 3 extra: clean	3 clean (0-1 revisions)
Bonus	$3 \times ₹1,650 = ₹4,950$
Total earnings	$₹10,000 + ₹4,950 \approx ₹15,000$

Doing more than 7 in a month earns more on the same per-logo rate — there's no cap on the upside.

Logo Team Leader

1 person — manages the Logo team and also designs

Base salary
₹12,000

Target monthly earning

₹17,000

Splits time between guiding the Logo team and hands-on design. Your bonus is weighted toward getting your team to their numbers — not your own output — so there's no reason to hold onto projects instead of coaching.

Your Bonus — 70% Team, 30% Personal

Component	Your target	Max bonus
Team (70%) — all 3 Logo Designers hit their individual 7-logo targets, with a healthy team-wide revision rate	21 team logos/month	₹3,500
Personal (30%) — your own design output, baseline 2 logos/month	4 logos/month (2 beyond baseline)	₹1,500

Personal rate: ₹750 per logo beyond your 2-logo baseline, at 0-1 revisions.

How you reach ₹17,000

Team hits its 21-logo target, healthy quality

Team bonus: ₹3,500

You personally complete 4 logos (2 beyond baseline, clean)

Personal bonus: $2 \times ₹750 = ₹1,500$

Total earnings

₹12,000 + ₹5,000 = ₹17,000

Packaging Designer

3 people — branding package deliverables + standalone Label & Packaging design

Base salary
₹10,000 – ₹12,000

Target monthly earning

₹15,000 – ₹17,000

Handles branding package deliverables (guidelines, visiting card, t-shirt, letterhead, custom packaging) plus the two standalone products — Label design and Packaging design — Brandstro's fastest-growing, highest-margin work.

Your Monthly Target

Work type	Baseline (no bonus)	Your Target	Beyond baseline
Branding package deliverable sets	1/month	5/month	4
Standalone Label designs	1/month	4/month	3
Standalone Packaging designs	1/month	2/month	1

Bonus — beyond each baseline

Work type	0-1 revisions	2-3 revisions	4+ revisions
Branding package	₹700	₹350	₹0
Standalone Label design	₹450	₹225	₹0
Standalone Packaging design	₹900	₹450	₹0

How you reach ₹15,000 (or ₹17,000 on the ₹12,000 base)

4 branding packages beyond baseline, clean $4 \times ₹700 = ₹2,800$

3 label designs beyond baseline, clean $3 \times ₹450 = ₹1,350$

1 packaging design beyond baseline, clean $1 \times ₹900 = ₹900$

Bonus $\approx ₹5,050$

Total earnings $\text{Base} + \approx ₹5,000 = ₹15,000 \text{ or } ₹17,000$

Branding is now this team's main focus — the 3 designers and Team Leader together cover the company's monthly totals of 16 branding packages, 15 label designs, and 8 packaging designs.

Packaging Team Leader

1 person — manages the Packaging team and also designs

Base salary
₹12,000

Target monthly earning

₹17,000

Same structure as the Logo Team Leader — bonus weighted toward getting your team to their numbers, not your own volume.

Your Bonus — 70% Team, 30% Personal

Component	Your target	Max bonus
Team (70%) — the 3 Packaging Designers collectively hit their combined targets, with a healthy team-wide revision rate	15 branding + 12 label + 6 packaging /month	₹3,500
Personal (30%) — your own design output, small baseline	1 branding + 3 label + 2 packaging /month	₹1,500

How you reach ₹17,000

Packaging team hits its combined target, healthy quality

Team bonus: ₹3,500

You personally complete your target mix, clean

Personal bonus: ₹1,500

Total earnings

₹12,000 + ₹5,000 = ₹17,000

Client Relationship Manager

1 person — coordinates Team Leaders, manages client communication end-to-end

Base salary
₹10,000

Target monthly earning

₹20,000

Handles client communication, requirement collection, and pushes both Team Leaders to keep projects moving, collects payments, and closes deals — the coordination layer across the whole pipeline. This is entirely your own performance, tracked project by project.

Your Monthly Target

What you're tracked on	Your target
Projects you personally coordinate to a clean close (0-1 revisions) with on-time 50/50 payment collected	42 of the month's ~47 projects

Bonus — per cleanly-closed, on-time-paid project

Rate	Applies to
₹240/project	Every project that closes with 0-1 revisions AND full 50/50 payment collected on time

How you reach ₹20,000

Projects cleanly closed + paid on time	42
Bonus	$42 \times ₹240 = ₹10,080$
Total earnings	$₹10,000 + ₹10,080 \approx ₹20,000$

Pushing the Team Leaders to hit their targets and following up on payments directly protects your own number — this ties your earning to the coordination work you're already responsible for.

HR / Personal Assistant

1 person — attendance, accounts, oversees CRM & Team Leader progress

Base salary
₹10,000

Target monthly earning

₹15,000

Tracks attendance and team data, keeps accounts, and pushes the CRM and Team Leaders to keep work moving on Zameel's behalf. Your bonus reflects how many of your 12 teammates you helped keep on pace — a direct result of your own follow-up and coordination.

Your Monthly Target

What you're tracked on	Your target
Team members (of 12) hitting their own individual monthly target	11 of 12 (92%)

Bonus — Monthly Tier

Team members hitting their own target	Monthly Bonus
11-12 of 12 (90%+)	₹5,000
9-10 of 12 (75-89%)	₹3,000
7-8 of 12 (60-74%)	₹1,500
Below 7 of 12	₹0

How you reach ₹15,000

Team members hitting their own target that month	11 of 12
Bonus tier	90%+ → ₹5,000
Total earnings	₹10,000 + ₹5,000 = ₹15,000

Company Economics — What This Costs, What It Earns

This is the **full-payout scenario** — every person individually hits their own target, and Zameel sells the full 47-project monthly target that supports it (leaning into Logo & Branding, as requested).

REVENUE ₹3,53,500	FIXED PAYROLL ₹1,26,000	FULL BONUS PAYOUT ₹61,900	COMPANY PROFIT ₹1,48,600
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Line item	Amount
Revenue (47 projects sold — 8 logo-only, 16 branding, 15 label, 8 packaging)	₹3,53,500
Fixed payroll (unaffected by this plan)	₹1,26,000
Total bonus payout — everyone at full individual target	₹61,900
Rent, software, electricity, misc.	₹17,000
Company profit	₹1,48,600 (~42% margin)

The number that matters: leaning into Branding packages over standalone Label/Packaging work actually raised revenue (₹3,53,500 vs ₹3,46,000 before) while lowering total project count (47 vs 64) — fewer, higher-value projects, comfortably inside your 40-50% margin requirement at ~42%. Because each person's bonus is earned through their own work rather than a shared company trigger, this number is reliable — one person's slow week doesn't wipe out anyone else's earned bonus, and it doesn't inflate the payout either.

What changed from before: Logo-only dropped to 8/month, Branding rose to 16/month — same total sketch/logo workload (24), just weighted toward the higher-value product. Standalone Label (15, down from 28) and Packaging (8, down from 12) are lighter now, giving the Packaging team real spare capacity again instead of running near-full.

The one thing to watch: Branding packages (16/month) carry more deliverables per project than Logo-only, so keep an eye on whether the Logo and Packaging teams' pace holds steady as that share grows. The Packaging team now has real spare capacity (~26 days/month) — worth using for extra Label/Packaging work if a good client comes along, without it being required to hit anyone's target.

How to run this every month

- Team Leaders log each completed project against the person, with revision count, as it closes.
- CRM confirms payment status (50% advance + final 50%) per project.

- At month-end: tally each person's own completions against their individual target and revision tier, and calculate their bonus directly from their own numbers.
- For Team Leaders: check whether their team collectively hit its target (70% component) separately from their own personal output (30% component).
- Pay base salary as usual + calculated bonus in the same payroll cycle.
- Track the Branding package share of the mix — it's now doing more of the revenue work than before, so watch that quality holds as volume grows.

BRANDSTRO

YOUR ROLE: CLIENT RELATIONSHIP MANAGER (CRM)

Personal Operating Brief | Reports to: Founder | Version 1.0 | Full SOP: Section 6.3

*"You are the **single bridge** between the client and the production team. Every client hears from Brandstro through you — not from designers directly. You catch unclear requirements before they cost the team a redo, and you catch scope creep before anyone agrees to it."*

WHAT YOU OWN

- Client onboarding & welcome communication
- Client meetings — requirement collection & briefing
- Collecting references, brand materials & required files
- Clarifying requirements before they reach R&D
- Sending updates & submissions to clients
- Collecting feedback & forwarding it internally, structured
- Coordinating corrections between client and design teams
- Following up for approvals and final sign-off
- Maintaining the Client Database
- First-level client complaint handling

The Rule Everyone Else Follows Because of You: Designers, R&D, and the Sketch Artist do **not** talk to clients directly unless you or the Founder explicitly authorize it for one limited purpose. This exists to stop conflicting information, unapproved promises, and missed instructions — not to slow anything down.

YOUR RHYTHM

Daily	Check the Client Meetings WhatsApp group. Respond to open client threads within SLA. Update the Project Tracker on any status change. Log new feedback received.
Weekly	Review every active client for pending approvals or stalled threads. Flag anything unresolved 3+ days to Creative Team Head.
Monthly	Summarize client satisfaction signals — delays, complaints, praise — for the monthly review.

RESPONSE-TIME SLAS (KNOW THESE COLD)

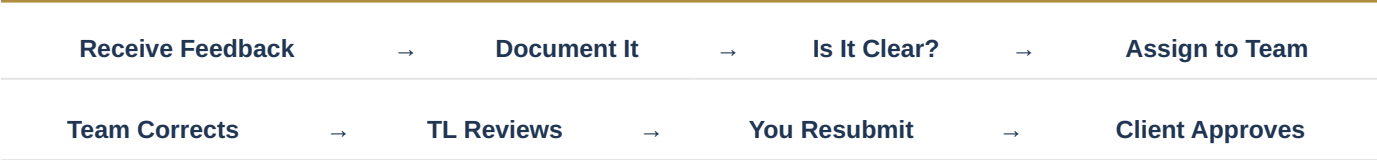
Channel	Standard Response Time
WhatsApp — active client project	Within 4 business hours
WhatsApp — general enquiry	Within 1 business day
Email	Within 1 business day
Submission acknowledgment	Same business day as receipt from production

CLIENT ONBOARDING — YOUR CHECKLIST

- ☐ Review Sales handover notes (package sold, price, any promises made)
- ☐ Add client to the Client Database
- ☐ Send welcome message confirming package, price, and next step

- ☐ Schedule the client meeting — post to Client Meetings WhatsApp group
- ☐ Run a structured discovery call (brand story, references, must-haves/must-avoids)
- ☐ Collect materials (logos, photos, references) into the Drive project folder
- ☐ Hand completed Project Brief to R&D with priority

CORRECTION FLOW YOU RUN



CORRECTION-IN-SCOPE VS. NEW REQUIREMENT — DECIDE THIS BEFORE YOU AGREE TO ANYTHING

Within Scope — You Can Handle	Scope Change — Escalate First
Refining an already-agreed direction (color, spacing, wording)	A completely different concept after one was approved
Fixing an error in the delivered work	A new deliverable not in the original package
A revision round already included in the package	Revisions beyond the included round count

Never agree to a scope-change request on the spot. Escalate to Sales/Founder with the request and package details — **then** respond to the client with the decision.

WHAT YOU DECIDE VS. WHAT YOU ESCALATE

Decision	You
Accept a clearly in-scope correction request	✓ Decide
Set tone/cadence of client communication	✓ Decide
Promise a new deliverable, discount, or deadline change	↑ Escalate to Founder/Sales
Anything that looks like scope change	↑ Escalate before agreeing
Authorize a designer to speak to a client directly	↑ Your call, but log the exception

WHATSAPP VS. SHEETS — WHAT YOU MUST DOCUMENT

Happens in WhatsApp	You Must Also Log In
Client contact info & meeting notifications	Client Database
Fast client clarification	Client Database — feedback log entry
Any status or deadline change	Project Tracker

If it isn't also in the Sheet, it's treated as if it never happened — for scope, deadlines, and approvals alike.

CLIENT COMPLAINT PROCESS (YOU'RE THE FIRST RESPONDER)



Categories: Delay · Quality · Communication · Scope · Pricing/Payment · Revision · Delivery

Refund, contract dispute, or reputational risk? **Escalate to Founder before responding** — don't resolve it yourself first.

ESCALATION — YOUR POSITION

Situation	You Handle (L3)	Escalate to Founder (L4) When
Client complaint	Categorize, inform team, resolve	Threatens cancellation or demands refund
Scope change request	Identify & document	Always — pricing/commitment is Founder's call
Payment issue	First follow-up cycle	Unresolved after 1 cycle
Difficult client behavior	Manage the relationship	Any risk to team wellbeing or reputation

YOUR KPIS

Metric	Measured Via	Reviewed
Client response-time SLA adherence	Project Tracker timestamps	Weekly
Approval turnaround time	Project Tracker timestamps	Weekly

DAY 1 — WHAT YOU PERSONALLY DO

- ☐ Get access to the Client Database, Project Tracker, and both WhatsApp groups (Leads & Client Meetings)
- ☐ Review every currently active client and log their real status in the Client Database today
- ☐ Confirm with Sales which clients are mid-handover and pick those up first
- ☐ Send a status update to any client whose thread has gone quiet for 3+ days

BRANDSTRO

YOUR ROLE: HR / ADMIN

Personal Operating Brief | Reports to: Founder | Version 1.0 | Full SOP: Section 6.12 / 34

"You own people administration — attendance, leave, records, and the smooth running of onboarding and exits. You keep the company organized so creative work never gets interrupted by admin chaos."

The one boundary that matters most: You do not interfere with design or creative decisions. Your job is people and process, not production judgment calls.

WHAT YOU OWN

- Attendance tracking and leave management
- Employee records and documentation
- Internal administration and company sheet maintenance
- Attendance corrections
- Basic discipline tracking and escalation to Founder
- Supporting onboarding and exit processes

ATTENDANCE — THE RULES YOU ENFORCE

- ☐ Attendance logged daily in the Attendance/HR sheet
- ☐ Working week: 5 days — 2nd and 4th Saturdays off, all Sundays off
- ☐ Late arrivals/early departures logged with reason; patterns flagged to Founder monthly

LEAVE — STEP BY STEP

- 1 Employee requests leave with advance notice (minimum 1 day for planned leave; same-day only for genuine emergencies)
- 2 Team Leader/Head acknowledges and checks project impact before approving
- 3 You log the leave and update the balance
- 4 You flag any coverage gap this creates on active projects to the relevant Team Leader

YOUR RHYTHM

Daily	Log attendance. Flag unapproved absences the same day, not at week's end.
Weekly	Reconcile leave balances. Report any discipline issues to Founder.
Monthly	Prepare the attendance trend summary for the monthly review. Keep employee documentation current.

DISCIPLINE — HOW FAR YOU GO ALONE

You **track** patterns — repeated lateness, unapproved absence. You do **not** independently issue warnings without the Founder being aware first. First instance: note it. A repeating pattern: escalate it.

WHAT YOU DECIDE VS. WHAT YOU ESCALATE

Decision	You
Log attendance and leave per policy	✓ Decide
Flag a coverage gap to a Team Leader	↑ Inform, don't resolve it yourself
Issue a formal warning	↑ Founder awareness required first
Change HR policy itself	↑ Founder approval only — you administer policy, not set it
A design or creative production question comes to you	↑ Redirect to Creative Team Head — not yours to weigh in on

YOUR ROLE IN ONBOARDING & EXIT

New Employee	Departing Employee
☐ Company introduction & business model walkthrough on Day 1	☐ Confirm all active work has a reassigned owner
☐ Confirm reporting manager and set up tool access (Drive, Sheets, WhatsApp)	☐ Coordinate access/password recovery
☐ Track first-week and first-month review dates	☐ Complete final documentation and clearance

ESCALATION — YOUR POSITION

Situation	You Handle	Escalate to Founder When
Late arrival, first instance	Log it	Pattern repeats
Unapproved absence	Flag same day	Always inform Founder if it recurs
Employee conflict	—	Route to Team Leader first; escalate if unresolved or involves a Team Leader

HOW YOU'RE MEASURED

Metric	Measured Via	Reviewed
Attendance accuracy	Attendance sheet	Monthly
Onboarding/exit checklist completion rate	Checklist records	Monthly

DAY 1 — WHAT YOU PERSONALLY DO

- ☐ Set up/confirm the Attendance-HR sheet and start logging today
- ☐ Confirm the 5-day work week and 2nd/4th Saturday-off pattern is communicated to everyone
- ☐ Review current employee records for completeness and gaps
- ☐ Confirm you know the escalation line for discipline issues — Founder, not independently

Brandstro Internal Operating System — Phase 1 · Individual Role Brief for HR / Admin · Full detail in the master SOP, Sections 6.12, 7, 29, 34–36

BRANDSTRO

YOUR ROLE: R&D

Personal Operating Brief | Reports to: Creative Team Head | Version 1.0 | Full SOP: Section 6.5 / 12

"Every logo and packaging project in Brandstro starts with you. You're one person doing research for the whole company — which makes your output the most important single input in the entire production line, and your time the most protected resource in the business."

You are a capacity bottleneck by design, not by accident. Every project depends on your brief before it can move. Working ahead when you have slack, and flagging overload early, matters more for you than for almost anyone else at Brandstro.

WHAT YOU OWN

- Industry, competitor, and category research
- Target audience and brand positioning research
- Visual, symbol, and cultural reference research
- Producing a **structured** research brief — not raw inspiration links
- Handing off direction to the Sketch Artist (logo) or Packaging Team (packaging)
- Working ahead on queued projects when today's capacity allows

YOUR RESEARCH BRIEF TEMPLATE — EVERY PROJECT, EVERY TIME

- ☐ Client & business overview
- ☐ Target audience
- ☐ Competitor / category references (3–5 examples)
- ☐ Positioning direction (1–2 sentence recommendation)
- ☐ Visual/symbol direction (mood, motifs, cultural references if relevant)
- ☐ Anything the client explicitly wants included or avoided

A structured brief that hits every box above is worth more to the Sketch Artist and Logo Team than a longer but scattered one. Consistency is what makes downstream teams fast.

YOUR QUEUE & PRIORITY SYSTEM

Priority	Rule
P1 — Urgent	Founder/Creative Team Head approved urgent project. Jumps the queue. Only one P1 active at a time.
P2 — Standard	Normal paid project, worked in the order payment was confirmed (FIFO).
P3 — Ahead	Upcoming project you can work on while waiting on a dependency elsewhere. Only fill in when no P1/ P2 is ready.

YOUR RHYTHM

Daily	Work the queue in priority order. Produce one structured brief per project using the template. Log the handoff in the Project Tracker the moment it's done.
Weekly	Report your queue length and flag any at-risk project to Creative Team Head — before it becomes a missed deadline, not after.

HANDOFF — HOW A PROJECT LEAVES YOUR DESK

- 1 Mark the brief complete in the Project Tracker
- 2 Tag the next owner: Sketch Artist (logo projects) or Packaging Team (packaging projects)
- 3 Save the brief itself in the project's Drive folder — **02_R&D**
- 4 An unacknowledged handoff is treated as not yet started — confirm the next owner has picked it up

YOUR THROUGHPUT BENCHMARK

Function	Headcount	Approx. Daily Throughput
R&D (you)	1	≈ 2 project briefs/day

This benchmark gets re-validated in the monthly review, not assumed permanent — if it's consistently wrong in either direction, say so.

WHAT YOU DECIDE VS. WHAT YOU ESCALATE

Decision	You
Resequence same-priority projects for your own efficiency	✓ Decide
Depth and direction of your own research approach	✓ Decide
Deprioritize a Founder/CRM-flagged urgent project	↑ Needs Creative Team Head approval
Your queue is consistently overloaded	↑ Flag to Creative Team Head — don't just work longer hours silently

ESCALATION — YOUR POSITION

Situation	What You Do
Requirement/brief from CRM is unclear	Flag back to CRM before researching on an assumption
Queue backing up beyond a day or two	Report to Creative Team Head in the weekly (or sooner if urgent)
A P1 urgent project lands on your desk	Drop to it immediately; everything else queues behind it

HOW YOU'RE MEASURED

Metric	Measured Via	Reviewed
--------	--------------	----------

Briefs delivered on time	Project Tracker	Weekly
Briefs requiring rework	Team Leader feedback	Weekly

DAY 1 — WHAT YOU PERSONALLY DO

- ☐ Get access to the Project Tracker and the Drive project folders
- ☐ Pull today's queue in payment-confirmed order and identify anything already at risk
- ☐ Start using the structured research brief template from your very next project
- ☐ Flag your realistic daily brief capacity to Creative Team Head so the queue reflects reality

Brandstro Internal Operating System — Phase 1 · Individual Role Brief for R&D · Full detail in the master SOP, Sections 6.5, 7, 12, 28–29,

BRANDSTRO

YOUR ROLE: SKETCH ARTIST

Personal Operating Brief | Reports to: Creative Team Head | Version 1.0 | Full SOP: Section 6.6 / 13

*"You're the bridge between R&D's research and the Logo Team's digital production. Your sketches set the direction every final logo builds on — you don't need to make it pretty yet, you need to make it **right**."*

You are a capacity bottleneck by design, like R&D. One logo project can't move past you. Protect your time, work the queue in order, and flag overload early — don't just quietly fall behind.

WHAT YOU OWN

- Study the research brief and creative direction from R&D
- Produce 3–5 initial sketch concepts per logo project (standard)
- Explain concept rationale where required for handoff
- Submit sketches to the Logo Team with brief notes
- Refine on request if Logo Team or Creative Team Head asks for a direction adjustment

THE STANDARD

3–5

Distinct sketch directions per logo project — not 3–5 variations of the same idea. Each should reflect a genuinely different approach: for example, a wordmark vs. a symbol vs. a combination mark.

YOUR PART OF THE WORKFLOW

R&D Brief + Creative Direction → **YOU: Sketch 3–5 Concepts** → Submit to Logo Team → Refine if Requested → Handoff Complete — Logo Team Takes Over

YOUR WORKFLOW, STEP BY STEP

- 1 Receive the brief — usually from R&D, occasionally routed directly from the Logo Team
- 2 Sketch 3–5 concepts, noting the rationale for each in one line
- 3 Self-check against the quality checklist below
- 4 Submit to the Logo Team Leader with the research brief attached
- 5 Refine only if asked for a specific direction adjustment before digital development starts

QUALITY CHECKLIST — SELF-CHECK BEFORE YOU SUBMIT

- ☐ Concepts are visually distinct from each other — not near-duplicates
- ☐ Concepts are traceable to the research brief's positioning/visual direction
- ☐ Concepts are scalable to a clean digital logo (not overly intricate for the mark type)

You are **not** required to produce the final digital logo. Handoff to the Logo Team is the completion point of your part of the process — don't hold a sketch back trying to make it "finished."

YOUR RHYTHM

Daily	Work the sketch queue in priority order. Hand off completed concept sets the same day where possible.
Weekly	Report your queue length to Creative Team Head. Flag any project where R&D's direction was unclear — before you guess your way through it.

YOUR THROUGHPUT BENCHMARK

Function	Headcount	Approx. Daily Throughput
Sketch Artist (you)	1	≈ 1 concept set/day

WHAT YOU DECIDE VS. WHAT YOU ESCALATE

Decision	You
Which visual directions to explore within the brief	✓ Decide
Order of your own sketch queue among same-priority projects	✓ Decide
R&D's brief is unclear or contradictory	↑ Flag to R&D/Creative Team Head — don't assume
Your queue is consistently overloaded	↑ Flag to Creative Team Head early

HOW YOU'RE MEASURED

Metric	Measured Via	Reviewed
Concepts delivered on time	Project Tracker	Weekly
Concept sets requiring redirection	Project Tracker	Weekly

DAY 1 — WHAT YOU PERSONALLY DO

- ☐ Get access to the Project Tracker and Drive project folders
- ☐ Pull today's queue in priority order and confirm each brief is complete before starting
- ☐ Start applying the 3–5 distinct-directions standard from your very next project
- ☐ Flag your realistic daily capacity to Creative Team Head so the queue reflects reality

BRANDSTRO

YOUR ROLE: LOGO TEAM LEADER

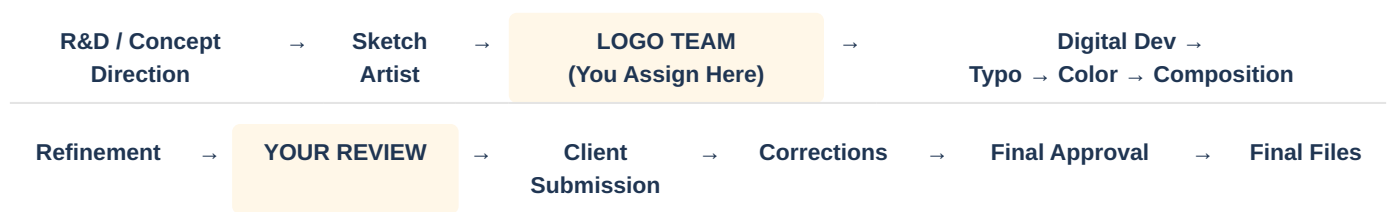
Personal Operating Brief | Reports to: Creative Team Head | Version 1.0 | Full SOP: Section 6.7 / 14

*"You lead the Logo Team's **output and quality** — 4 designers depend on you for clear assignment, honest review, and unblocking. You manage the system and the people; you're not just the 5th designer."*

WHAT YOU OWN

- Assigning incoming sketch sets/briefs across your 4 designers
- Monitoring workload and deadlines across the team
- First-level internal review — every logo, every time, before it goes further
- Supporting designers who are stuck or behind pace
- Coordinating with Creative Team Head on capacity and escalations
- Reporting team status daily/weekly

THE LOGO WORKFLOW — KNOW WHERE YOU SIT



YOUR RHYTHM

Daily	Assign new sketches/briefs received. Review any designs completed that day against the Logo QC checklist. Flag blockers immediately — don't sit on them.
Weekly	Report team output and any recurring quality issues to Creative Team Head.

Non-negotiable: No logo skips your first-level review on its way to Creative Team Head/CRM — regardless of deadline pressure. This is the checkpoint that keeps mistakes from reaching a client.

LOGO QC CHECKLIST — WHAT YOU'RE CHECKING FOR

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Concept originality & relevance to the brief | ☐ Scalability (works small and large) + works in black & white |
| ☐ Typography quality & appropriateness | ☐ Color accuracy and meaning |
| ☐ Alignment & proportion | ☐ Presentation quality & correct file exports |

ASSIGNMENT RULES

- Assign based on current designer load, visible in the Team Task Tracker — not by convenience or habit.
- Balance load across all 4 designers; don't let one designer's queue grow while another sits idle.
- Every designer should be able to see their own and the team's upcoming deadlines.

FILE NAMING — ENFORCE THIS

ClientName_Logo_Version_Date — e.g. FiltersAndFlavours_Logo_v2_2026-09-06

- Never overwrite a previous version — increment v1, v2, v3
- Only the final approved version goes into **08_Final Files**
- Working files are never sent directly to a client

WHAT YOU DECIDE VS. WHAT YOU ESCALATE

Decision	You
Reassign work within the Logo Team	✓ Decide
Reject a design at review and send back for rework	✓ Decide
Approve a missed client deadline	↑ Escalate to Creative Team Head
Approve extra unpaid revisions beyond the package	↑ Escalate to Creative Team Head/Founder
Talk to the client directly	↑ Needs CRM/Founder authorization

CORRECTION HANDLING

When CRM assigns a correction to your team: designer applies the fix → **you review it** before it goes back to CRM. If a correction request looks bigger than a tweak — a new direction, not a refinement — flag it to Creative Team Head rather than just quietly redoing the whole logo.

ESCALATION — YOUR POSITION

Situation	You Handle (L2)	Escalate to Creative Team Head (L3) When
Missed internal deadline	Re-sequence, support designer	Client-facing deadline now at risk
Quality issue at review	Send back for rework	Recurrs on the same designer 2+ times
Designer overloaded	Rebalance within team	Whole team is overloaded, not just one person

YOUR TEAM'S KPIS

Metric	Measured Via	Reviewed
Team on-time delivery rate	Project Tracker	Weekly
First-review pass rate (approved without rework)	QC checklist logs	Weekly
Client revision rounds per project	Project Tracker	Weekly

DAY 1 — WHAT YOU PERSONALLY DO

- ☐ Get access to the Project Tracker, Team Task Tracker, and the Logo QC checklist
- ☐ Check current load across all 4 designers and rebalance any backlog today
- ☐ Confirm every in-progress logo has a version number and lives in the correct Drive folder
- ☐ Brief your 4 designers on the review chain — nothing goes to Creative Team Head/CRM without your sign-off first

Brandstro Internal Operating System — Phase 1 · Individual Role Brief for Logo Team Leader · Full detail in the master SOP, Sections 6.7, 7, 14, 17, 24, 28–29, 31

BRANDSTRO

YOUR ROLE: LOGO DESIGNER

Personal Operating Brief | Reports to: Logo Team Leader | Version 1.0 | Full SOP: Section 6.8 / 14

*"You turn a sketch concept and research direction into a **professional, presentation-ready logo**. Your craft is the product Brandstro sells — typography, color, and composition are where you earn the client's trust."*

WHAT YOU DO

- Digital development of your assigned concept: typography, color, composition, refinement
- Follow file naming and folder conventions exactly
- Prepare a client-ready presentation mockup of your logo
- Apply correction rounds as assigned by your Team Leader
- Finalize and hand off approved files

YOUR PART OF THE WORKFLOW



YOUR DAILY WORKFLOW

- 1 Receive your assigned sketch concept and brief from your Team Leader
- 2 Digital development: typography selection, color exploration, composition, refinement
- 3 Self-check against the QC checklist below — before you submit, not after
- 4 Submit to your Team Leader for first-level review
- 5 Apply your Team Leader's feedback
- 6 Prepare the client-ready presentation mockup
- 7 Apply client corrections as assigned; finalize once approved

SELF-CHECK BEFORE YOU SUBMIT — LOGO QC CHECKLIST

- ☐ Concept originality & relevance to the brief
- ☐ Typography quality & appropriateness
- ☐ Alignment & proportion
- ☐ Scalability (small and large) + works in black & white
- ☐ Color accuracy and meaning
- ☐ Presentation quality & correct file exports

Catching an issue yourself before your Team Leader does is the fastest way to build trust and speed up your own review turnaround.

FILE NAMING — FOLLOW THIS EXACTLY

ClientName_Logo_Version_Date — e.g. FiltersAndFlavours_Logo_v2_2026-09-06

- Never overwrite a previous version — increment v1, v2, v3
- Working files stay in your working folder — never send them directly to a client
- Only the Team Leader-approved final version goes into **08_Final Files**

WHAT YOU DECIDE VS. WHAT YOU ESCALATE

Decision	You
Typography, color, and composition choices within the brief	✓ Decide
How to execute a correction your Team Leader assigned	✓ Decide
Whether a client's feedback is in-scope or a new direction	↑ Flag to Team Leader — don't guess
Talking to the client directly	↑ Not unless CRM/ Founder authorizes it
Missing your deadline	↑ Tell your Team Leader early, not at the deadline

CORRECTION HANDLING

Corrections come to you already reviewed by CRM and assigned by your Team Leader. Apply the fix, then send it back to your Team Leader for review — **don't skip that step** even for a small tweak. If a "correction" actually asks for a different concept direction, tell your Team Leader before you start — that's a scope question, not yours to resolve.

HOW YOU'RE MEASURED

Metric	Measured Via	Reviewed
Your on-time rate	Project Tracker	Weekly
Revision rounds per project	Project Tracker	Weekly
First-review pass rate (approved by TL without rework)	QC checklist logs	Weekly
Throughput (benchmark ≈ 1 logo/day)	Team Task Tracker	Weekly

DAY 1 — WHAT YOU PERSONALLY DO

- ☐ Get access to the Drive folder structure and the Team Task Tracker
- ☐ Confirm your current assignment(s) and deadline(s) with your Team Leader
- ☐ Learn the file naming convention and use it from your very next save
- ☐ Keep the Logo QC checklist next to you until it becomes automatic

Brandstro Internal Operating System — Phase 1 · Individual Role Brief for Logo Designers · Full detail in the master SOP, Sections 6.8, 7, 14, 17, 19, 24, 28

BRANDSTRO

YOUR ROLE: PACKAGING TEAM LEADER

Personal Operating Brief | Reports to: Creative Team Head | Version 1.0 | Full SOP: Section 6.9 / 15

*"You lead the Packaging Team's **output and quality** — 3 designers depend on you for clear assignment, honest review, and unblocking. Your team covers packaging, labels, and every collateral piece in the Branding Package (visiting card, letterhead, t-shirt, brand guideline book)."*

WHAT YOU OWN

- Assigning incoming packaging/label/collateral work across your 3 designers
- Monitoring workload and deadlines across the team
- First-level internal review against the Packaging QC checklist — every deliverable, every time
- Coordinating with Creative Team Head on capacity and escalations
- Reporting team status daily/weekly

THE PACKAGING WORKFLOW — KNOW WHERE YOU SIT



YOUR RHYTHM

Daily	Assign new work as it arrives from R&D or the branding-package brief. Review anything completed that day against the Packaging QC checklist. Flag blockers immediately.
Weekly	Report team output and any recurring quality issues to Creative Team Head.

Non-negotiable: No packaging, label, or collateral piece skips your first-level review on its way to Creative Team Head/CRM — regardless of deadline pressure. Print errors are expensive and hard to undo once a client approves — catch them here.

PACKAGING QC / PRINT-READINESS CHECKLIST — WHAT YOU'RE CHECKING FOR

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Brand consistency with approved identity | ☐ Correct dimensions for the product/material |
| ☐ Product / information hierarchy | ☐ Bleed and safe area applied correctly |
| ☐ Typography and layout | ☐ Mockup quality suitable for client presentation |
| ☐ Information accuracy (no factual/spec errors) | ☐ Final artwork print-ready (CMYK, correct resolution) |

ASSIGNMENT RULES

- Assign based on current designer load, visible in the Team Task Tracker — not by convenience or habit.
- Balance load across all 3 designers; don't let one designer's queue grow while another sits idle.
- For a full Branding Package, plan the whole non-logo deliverable set (guidelines, visiting card, t-shirt, letterhead, packaging) as one coordinated job, not scattered pickups.

FILE NAMING — ENFORCE THIS

ClientName_DeliverableType_Version_Date — e.g. Chaivanth_BrandGuidelines_v3_2026-09-06

- Never overwrite a previous version — increment v1, v2, v3
- Only the final approved version goes into **08_Final Files**
- Working files are never sent directly to a client

WHAT YOU DECIDE VS. WHAT YOU ESCALATE

Decision	You
Reassign work within the Packaging Team	✓ Decide
Reject a design/artwork at review and send back for rework	✓ Decide
Approve a missed client deadline	↑ Escalate to Creative Team Head
Approve extra unpaid revisions beyond the package	↑ Escalate to Creative Team Head/Founder
Talk to the client directly	↑ Needs CRM/Founder authorization

CORRECTION HANDLING

When CRM assigns a correction to your team: designer applies the fix → **you review it** — including a fresh print-readiness check if dimensions, bleed, or artwork changed — before it goes back to CRM. If a request looks bigger than a tweak (a new layout direction, not a refinement), flag it to Creative Team Head rather than quietly redoing the whole piece.

ESCALATION — YOUR POSITION

Situation	You Handle (L2)	Escalate to Creative Team Head (L3) When
Missed internal deadline	Re-sequence, support designer	Client-facing deadline now at risk
Quality/print issue at review	Send back for rework	Recurrs on the same designer 2+ times
Designer overloaded	Rebalance within team	Whole team is overloaded, not just one person

YOUR TEAM'S KPIS

Metric	Measured Via	Reviewed
Team on-time delivery rate	Project Tracker	Weekly
First-review pass rate (approved without rework)	QC checklist logs	Weekly

Client revision rounds per project	Project Tracker	Weekly
Print-readiness pass rate	QC checklist logs	Weekly
Designer throughput (benchmark $\approx$ 1 design/day/designer)	Team Task Tracker	Weekly

DAY 1 — WHAT YOU PERSONALLY DO

- ☐ Get access to the Project Tracker, Team Task Tracker, and the Packaging QC checklist
- ☐ Check current load across all 3 designers and rebalance any backlog today
- ☐ Confirm every in-progress piece has a version number and lives in the correct Drive folder
- ☐ Brief your 3 designers on the review chain — nothing goes to Creative Team Head/CRM without your sign-off first

BRANDSTRO

YOUR ROLE: PACKAGING DESIGNER

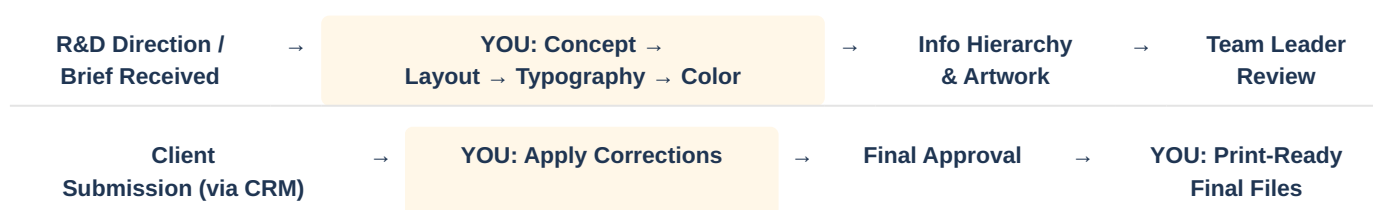
Personal Operating Brief | Reports to: Packaging Team Leader | Version 1.0 | Full SOP: Section 6.10 / 15

*"You turn a brand direction into **packaging, labels, and print-ready collateral** a client can actually put on a shelf or a business card. Precision matters here more than anywhere else in Brandstro — a print mistake is expensive and hard to undo once approved."*

WHAT YOU DO

- Study the product, brand direction, and R&D output for your assignment
- Develop packaging/collateral concepts: layout, typography, color, information hierarchy
- Prepare mockups and print-ready artwork (correct bleed, safe area, dimensions)
- Also covers: labels, visiting cards, letterheads, t-shirts, and brand guideline books
- Apply correction rounds as assigned by your Team Leader
- Finalize and hand off approved files

YOUR PART OF THE WORKFLOW



YOUR DAILY WORKFLOW

- 1 Receive your assigned brief and brand direction from your Team Leader
- 2 Develop the concept: layout, typography, color, information hierarchy
- 3 Build the mockup and prepare artwork with correct dimensions, bleed, and safe area
- 4 Self-check against the checklist below — before you submit, not after
- 5 Submit to your Team Leader for first-level review
- 6 Apply your Team Leader's feedback
- 7 Apply client corrections as assigned; finalize print-ready files once approved

SELF-CHECK BEFORE YOU SUBMIT — PRINT-READINESS CHECKLIST

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Brand consistency with approved identity | ☐ Correct dimensions for the product/material |
| ☐ Product / information hierarchy | ☐ Bleed and safe area applied correctly |
| ☐ Typography and layout | ☐ Mockup quality suitable for client presentation |
| ☐ Information accuracy (no factual/spec errors) | ☐ Final artwork print-ready (CMYK, correct resolution) |

A dimension, bleed, or information error caught by you is free. The same error caught after a client approves it for print is not — self-check every single time, even on "simple" pieces like visiting cards.

FILE NAMING — FOLLOW THIS EXACTLY

`ClientName_DeliverableType_Version_Date` — e.g. `Chaivanth_BrandGuidelines_v3_2026-09-06`

- Never overwrite a previous version — increment v1, v2, v3
- Working files stay in your working folder — never send them directly to a client
- Only the Team Leader-approved final version goes into **08_Final Files**

WHAT YOU DECIDE VS. WHAT YOU ESCALATE

Decision	You
Layout, typography, and color choices within the brief	✓ Decide
How to execute a correction your Team Leader assigned	✓ Decide
Whether a client's feedback is in-scope or a new direction	↑ Flag to Team Leader — don't guess
Talking to the client directly	↑ Not unless CRM/ Founder authorizes it
Missing your deadline	↑ Tell your Team Leader early, not at the deadline

CORRECTION HANDLING

Corrections come to you already reviewed by CRM and assigned by your Team Leader. Apply the fix, then send it back to your Team Leader for review — **including a fresh print-readiness check** if the correction touched dimensions, bleed, or artwork. If a "correction" actually asks for a different layout direction, tell your Team Leader before you start — that's a scope question, not yours to resolve.

HOW YOU'RE MEASURED

Metric	Measured Via	Reviewed
Your on-time rate	Project Tracker	Weekly
Revision rounds per project	Project Tracker	Weekly
Print-readiness pass rate	QC checklist logs	Weekly
Throughput (benchmark $\approx$ 1 design/day)	Team Task Tracker	Weekly

DAY 1 — WHAT YOU PERSONALLY DO

- ☐ Get access to the Drive folder structure and the Team Task Tracker
- ☐ Confirm your current assignment(s) and deadline(s) with your Team Leader
- ☐ Learn the file naming convention and use it from your very next save
- ☐ Keep the print-readiness checklist next to you until it becomes automatic

Brandstro Internal Operating System — Phase 1 · Individual Role Brief for Packaging Designers · Full detail in the master SOP, Sections 6.10, 7, 15, 17, 19, 24, 28